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*Master's Degree in Data Science for Economics*

**From Data to Strategy:  
Optimizing Tourism Offerings in  
Ascoli Piceno**

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## Abstract

Tourism plays a fundamental role in the economic development of many Italian cities, including **Ascoli Piceno**, a destination with significant untapped potential. Despite its rich cultural, historical, and gastronomic heritage, the city has yet to establish itself as a highly competitive tourist destination compared to other Italian locations.

This project analyzes tourism data from various Italian cities to identify key trends in visitor segmentation, pricing models, and market positioning. To address this challenge, this study seeks to answer the following research question: ” *What is the optimal combination of pricing, positioning, and promotional strategies for Ascoli Piceno to increase tourism competitiveness?*”. By combining secondary data analysis with primary research through surveys, the project provides insights into tourist preferences, spending behavior, and the effectiveness of different promotional strategies. Additionally, financial factors—including cost structures, potential partnerships, and the role of influencer marketing—are examined to understand their impact on tourism promotion.

Using clustering techniques and strategic pricing models, the research proposes optimized tourism packages tailored to different market segments. The findings aim to offer evidence-based recommendations for Ascoli Piceno to improve its tourism appeal, increase visitor numbers, and strengthen its overall economic sustainability. Further research could explore the long-term effects of these strategies and identify additional factors that influence the competitiveness of tourist destinations.

# Chapter 1

## Introduction

### 1.1 Previous Work

This research originates from a project initially developed for the Marketing Analytics course within the Master’s Degree in Data Science for Economics, for the academic year 2022/2023, at the Università degli studi di Milano. The project had a similar objective to the present work, but was **carried out over a shorter time period** and primarily aimed at applying the techniques taught during the course, not too focused on delivering an in-depth analysis to the city. The course had a duration of almost 3 months, and the project had a duration of around 1 month. In view of this, **the earlier project presented several limitations**, apart from the short timeframe, which are addressed differently and in greater depth in the current thesis.

First, there was a significant limitation in the **qualitative interviews** conducted during the initial stage of the project (see *Appendix A* for an example of these interviews). The main objective of these interviews was to collect qualitative data about participants’ tourist behaviour, which would then serve as the basis for defining the final attributes to be analysed in the quantitative survey. The main limitation was that the interviews contained a small number of predefined questions that were very specific, **leaving little room for respondents to describe their genuine behaviour in a tourist destination**. Moreover, this limitation may have resulted in the **omission of potential attributes** that could have further enriched the study. These “open” questions were formulated so narrowly that interviewees often provided **very short answers**. Furthermore, the interviews lacked questions related to actual travel experiences, which resulted in a generalised understanding of certain tourist topics rather than experience-based insights.

Second, after the qualitative interviews stage, came the **definition of the**

**main attributes.** This phase also had its limitations regarding the project’s main goal, as the defined attributes were **very general**. Such generalization led to a limited analysis of tourist behaviour, mainly because attributes such as **price, food, culture, and accessibility**, among others, did not clearly describe specific tourist behaviours, and failed to describe important aspects that Ascoli Piceno could focus on. For instance, the attribute price could refer to food prices, accommodation costs, transportation costs, or even event ticket prices, among others. In addition, most of the interviews were not recorded, so the final transcriptions relied on the interviewer’s notes, making it impossible for other team members to verify them and maybe extract more valuable insights. Although the project’s final outcome was sufficient for the course’s goal, the definition of attributes could have been improved to achieve more precise and insightful results.

Third and last, the following stage was the **online survey**, which aimed to obtain quantitative data for the final results and analysis. Although the outcomes were satisfactory and considered sufficient for the course’s objective, **the total number of responses (80) was relatively low**. In terms of sample size, a target of at least 300 responses would have provided a larger and more diverse dataset, thereby strengthening the validity of the results. On the other hand, **some questions could have been removed** because they were already covered by others, or did not contribute at all. For example, respondents from Italy were asked an additional question: “From which Italian region are you?”. This question not only failed to add value to the analysis but was not even used. Another example is the question “How far would you be willing to travel for a weekend getaway?”, which aimed to assess the distance that respondents were willing to travel over a weekend. The main issue here was that the question assumed a short trip, thereby excluding the possibility of longer journeys, and again it did not add meaningful value due to its specificity. Another limitation of this survey was that **most questions did not allow for a deeper exploration of attributes**. Although there were questions designed to obtain a good description of each cluster, they failed to provide further insight into the rationale behind the order in which respondents ranked the attributes.

Following the online survey, several questions related to **Van Westendorp’s Price Sensitivity Meter**, explained in detail in *Chapter 3: Methodology*, were included. These questions targeted very specific cases, such as the Quintana event, the Ascoliva Festival, a wine tasting, and a city tour. However, the model is designed to estimate willingness to pay for a representative product within the target market. [13]. A more appropriate approach would have been to formulate a single, general question referring to a typical tourist package, in order to obtain results that are more representative and comparable.

Last but not least, **the survey was written in English, which excluded some potential respondents who spoke Spanish**, the third most spoken language globally, and widely used in many regions. Although English is often considered the universal language, including a Spanish version could have allowed more Spanish speakers, particularly those living in South America, to participate.

In summary, while the original project successfully met the requirements of the course and provided an initial exploration of the research topic, **these limitations constrained the depth, precision, and representativeness of its findings**. The present thesis builds upon that foundation, addressing them through a more extensive working time period, improved qualitative methods, a refined survey design, and a larger and more diverse sample.

## 1.2 Thesis Roadmap

Explain a little bit the idea, but this will be explained in depth later in literature

# Chapter 2

## Literature Review

This chapter aims to provide a comprehensive contextualization of the research by reviewing both **existing literature and relevant data** on tourism performance at different territorial levels. While the previous chapter introduced the motivations and objectives of this study, here the focus shifts toward a **broader and more analytical perspective**. The review is structured in three parts, progressing from the general to the specific.

The **first section** outlines the evolution of **tourism on a global scale**, emphasizing key trends, particularly the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic and the sector's subsequent recovery. It explores how international tourism flows have changed in recent years. **The second section** describes the **Italian context**, examining national trends and worldwide position. **The third and last section** reviews the **available data on tourism in Ascoli Piceno**, identifying key patterns or limitations. Together, these sections provide the necessary background to understand the motivations for this research and the added value of the current thesis.

### 2.1 Tourism on a Global Scale

**Tourism** is recognized as one of the most important economic sectors in the world. In 2019, it represented a significant share of the global economy, accounting for **7% of global trade**. However, despite its importance, tourism was also among the sectors **most severely impacted by the Covid-19 pandemic**, which affected not only global economies but also livelihoods, public services, and development opportunities in countries across all continents [1]. Now, four years after the onset of the pandemic, the sector has shown strong signs of recovery. International tourist arrivals have returned to **99% of 2019 levels**, signaling that tourism has bounced back from what is considered the worst crisis in its history [2]. As shown in *Figure 1.1*, in addition to the rebound in arrivals, there has also been a notable

rise in international tourism revenues. Total international tourism receipts reached **USD 1.7 trillion in 2024**, reflecting a 10.5% increase compared to 2023 and a 14.1% increase from 2019 in real terms [3].

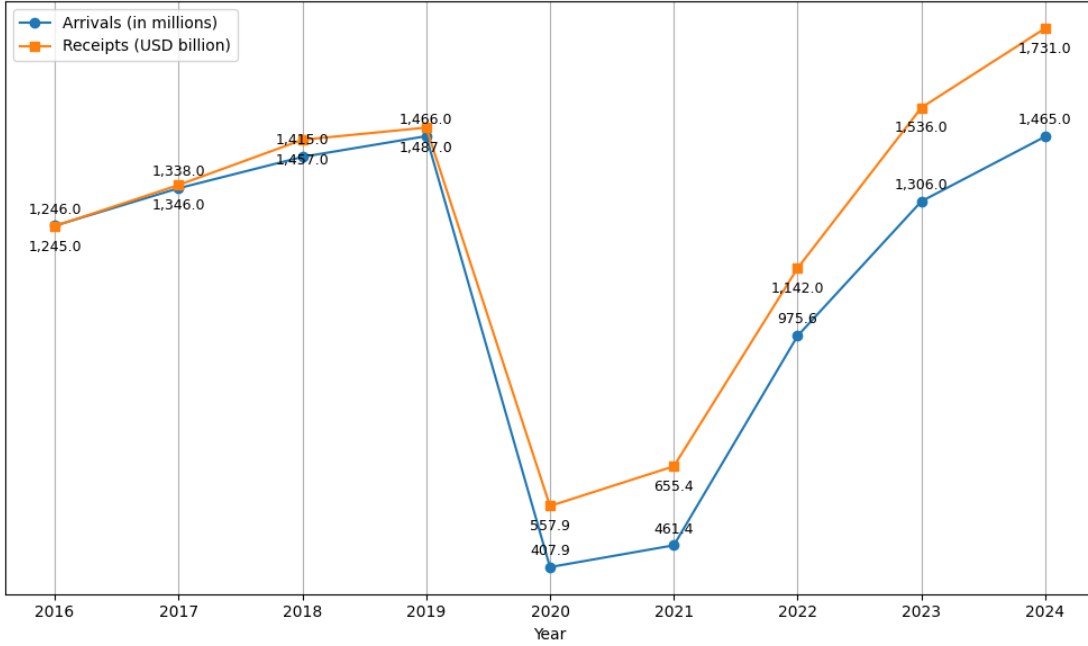


Figure 2.1: International Tourist Arrivals & Receipts. Source: UNWTO.

Moreover, when the data is broken down by region, it becomes clear that the **Middle East** continued to be the best-performing region in 2024. As shown in *Figure 1.2*, this region experienced a strong growth in tourist arrivals, which were **32% above 2019** levels and also showed a **1% increase compared to 2023**. In the case of **Africa**, the continent received **7% more** tourists than it did before the pandemic began, indicating a solid recovery. **Europe**, known as the world’s largest destination region, also showed positive results by recording **1% more** international tourist arrivals than in 2019. Meanwhile, the **Americas** managed to recover **97%** of its pre-pandemic tourist numbers, which is just a **3% decrease compared to 2019**. Finally, the region of **Asia and the Pacific** reached **87%** of its 2019 levels, showing a **13% decline** in international arrivals compared to the pre-pandemic period [2].

Nevertheless, when considering absolute values, **Europe continues to dominate global tourism** (see *Figure 1.3*). In **2024**, the region recorded approximately **755.7 million international tourist arrivals**, accounting for **52% of total global arrivals**. In terms of expenditure, Europe generated an estimated **USD 725.3 billion in international tourism receipts**, representing **42% of the world’s total** [3].

These not only confirm Europe’s position as the most visited region globally but also highlight its high capacity for **monetizing tourism flows**. The average

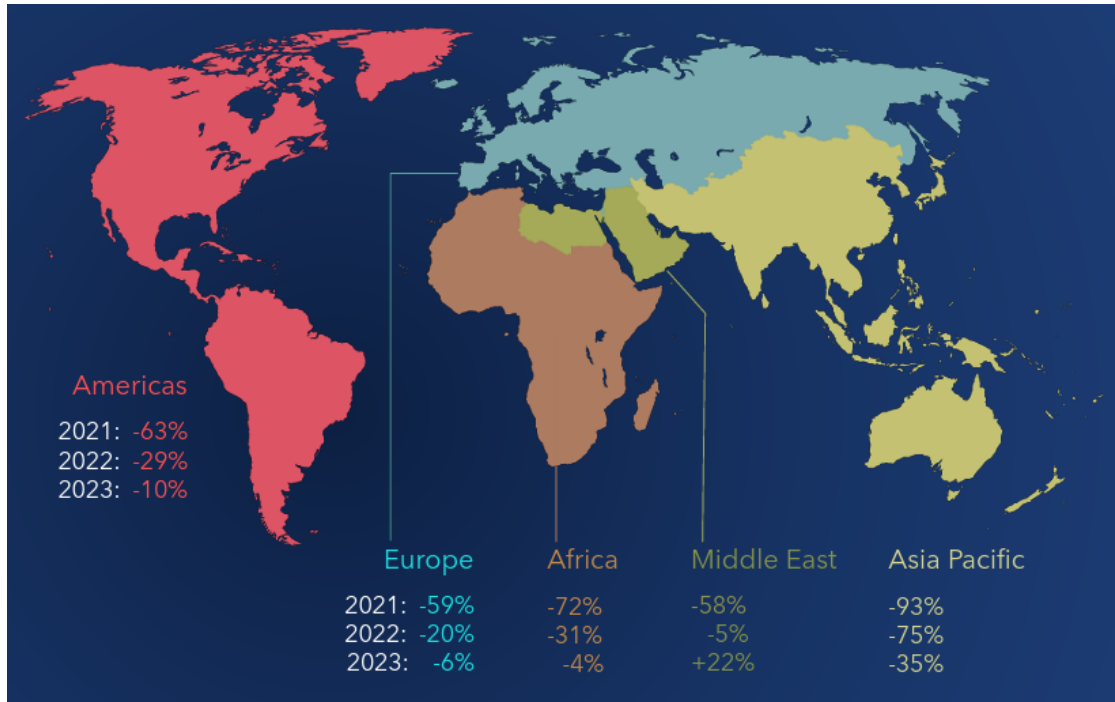


Figure 2.2: International Tourist Arrivals by Region (% change vs 2019). Source: UNWTO.

revenue per international arrival in Europe stood at around **USD 960**, while the global average is around **USD 1,182** per tourist in 2024. This gap highlights the advantage of Europe, where **shorter trips and lower per-capita spending are more common** compared to other top regions such as Americas (around USD 1,814) and Middle East (around USD 1,458).

## 2.2 The Italian Context

### 2.2.1 International Tourism and Overnight Stays

**Italy** continues to be a an important destination for international tourism, ranked among the **top 5** countries in the world, behind Türkiye who had 60.6 million visitors (*see Figure 1.4*). The country counts with a rich cultural heritage, natural beauty, and culinary excellence. However, recent trends show a mixed picture in terms of volume and economic impact. According to the United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO), Italy recorded **57.8 million** international tourist arrivals in 2024, which reflects a **10.4% decrease compared to 2019**. Despite the decline in visitor numbers, the country experienced a **strong financial recovery**, with international tourism receipts reaching **USD 58.7 billion**, an **18.5% increase over 2019** [3]. This highlights that the country has **not yet fully returned to its pre-pandemic levels** in terms of international arrivals, suggesting that there is still significant room for growth and strategic



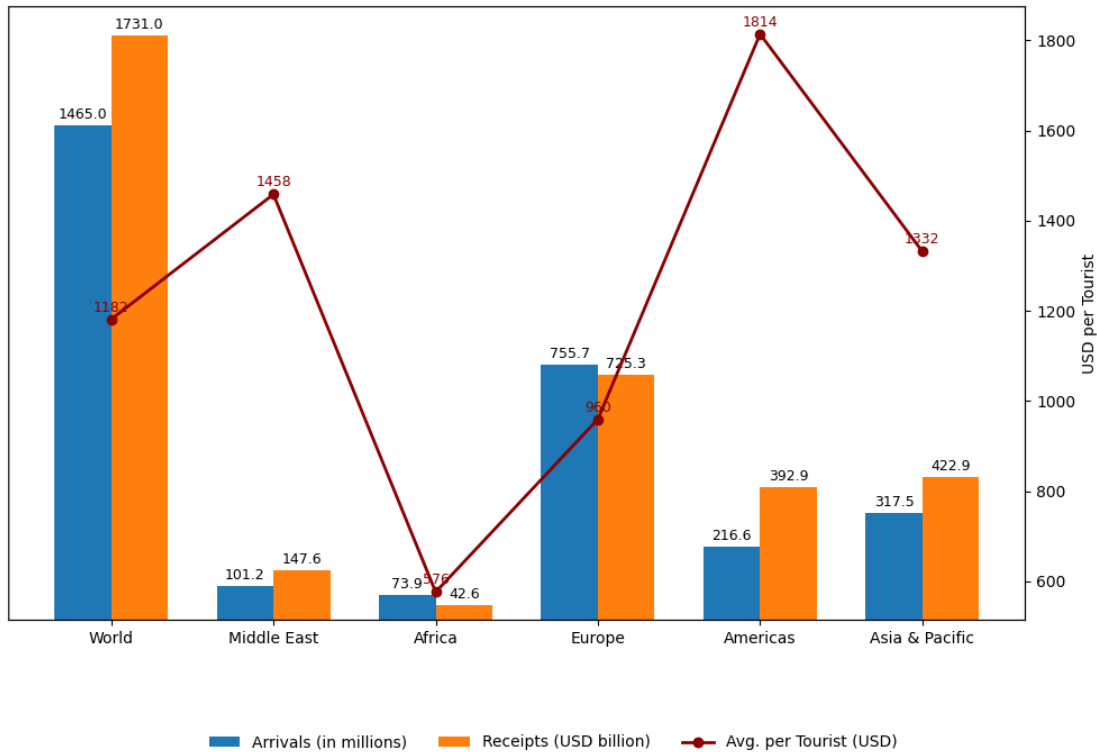


Figure 2.3: Arrivals, Receipts, and Avg. Spend per Tourist. Source: UNWTO.

interventions aimed at increasing the level of tourism.

Tourism in Italy is also measured by the number of **overnight stays in accommodations**, where the country positioned itself as the second-largest European destination in terms of total nights spent. According to the Italian National Institute of Statistics (ISTAT), Italy recorded **458.4 million overnight stays in 2024**, representing a **2.5% increase compared to 2023**. Among these, **foreign tourists** accounted for around **250 million nights**, a 6.8% increase, while domestic stays declined by 2.2%, totaling roughly 208 million nights. Foreign visitors now represent **54.6% of all overnight stays**, indicating that international tourism has regained its leading role in the Italian tourism sector. This trend became especially evident in the fourth quarter of 2024, when total overnight stays grew by 11.1%, mainly driven by international travelers (+15.6%), who outnumbered domestic tourists in that quarter for the first time [4].

## 2.2.2 Spending and Economic Contribution

According to the first edition of the “Tourism and Incoming Watch” report, developed by Nexi in collaboration with the National Tourism Observatory of the Ministry of Tourism, foreign travellers spent over €20.9 billion in Italy in 2024 using **payment cards** alone, representing a substantial **increase of 37.9% compared to 2022**. This figure reflects not only the volume of international

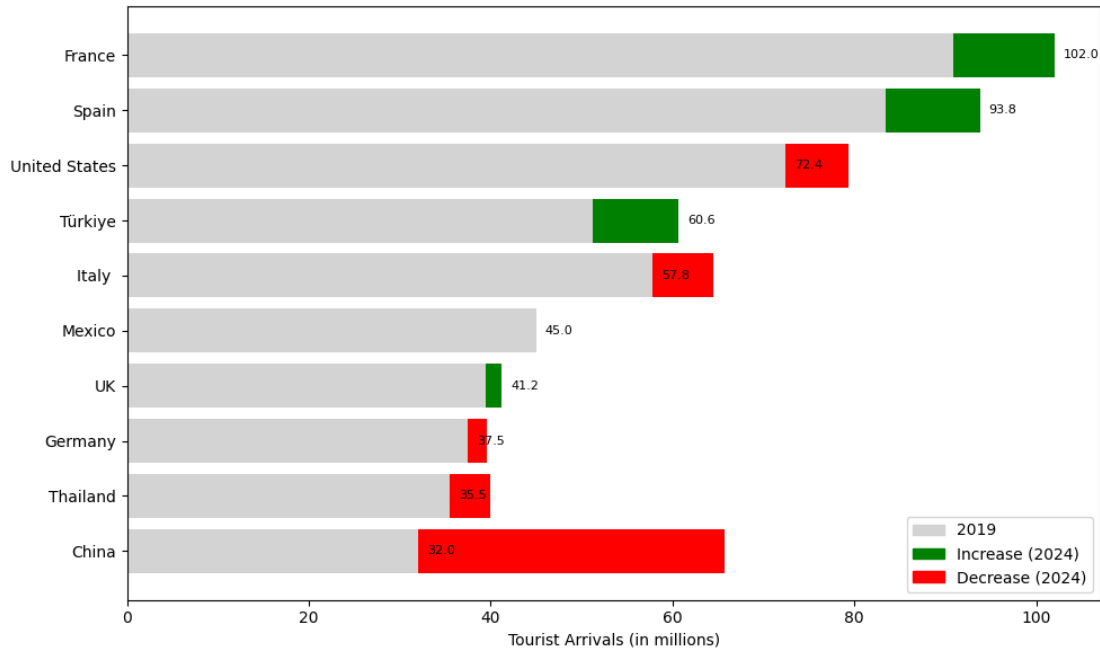


Figure 2.4: Ranking of International Arrivals by Country. Source: UNWTO.

tourism but also the growing role of digital payments in capturing economic value across the tourism sector.

The report also highlighted a notable diversification in the origin of **high-spending tourists**. Travellers from Brazil and Australia showed the largest increases in card-based spending, with growth rates of +155% and +100%, respectively. Meanwhile, US tourists remained the most significant contributors in absolute terms, with more than €3.8 billion spent, accounting for 18.3% of total foreign tourist expenditure. Tourists from Saudi Arabia (€913) and the United Arab Emirates (€822) had the highest average card spend per transaction, both nearly double the international average of €411.

In terms of spending categories, almost **half (49.6%)** of all international tourist expenditure in Italy went to **restaurants and accommodation services**. **Fashion and accessories** accounted for another **12.2%**, with visitors from Arab countries and Southeast Asia allocating an above-average share of their budgets to jewellery and department store shoppings.

The geographic distribution of tourist spending also reveals concentration patterns. Just **20 provinces generated 75% of all foreign tourist value**, confirming the dominance of Italy's major cultural and urban destinations: **Rome, Milan, Venice, Florence, and Naples**. These cities continue to attract visitors and generate sustained economic benefits for the national economy.

Among the most popular travel routes, the **Rome – Naples and Pompeii – Amalfi Coast** circuits generated the highest overall turnover for the third consecutive year, with a **31% increase** over the 2022–2024 period. However, the

**Rome – Florence – Venice** itinerary recorded the highest growth rate in the same period, rising by **+69.2%**. This trend suggests that traditional cultural circuits remain dominant, but their internal dynamics are shifting due to changing tourist preferences and purchasing behaviors.

Another key finding is the **decline in tourism seasonality**. Thanks to diversified travel flows and evolving preferences, international visitor demand is now **more evenly distributed throughout the year**. This has reinforced Italy’s profile as a **year-round destination**, which contributes to greater economic resilience and offers new opportunities for regional development beyond the summer peak.

## 2.3 Ascoli Piceno

**Ascoli Piceno** is a historic city located in the **Marche region of central Italy**, known for its rich cultural heritage, well-preserved medieval architecture, and local traditions. It is a city of ancient origins, once a strategic Roman center along the Via Salaria. Known as the **“City of a Hundred Towers”**, it has one of the most elegant and well-preserved historical centers in Italy, largely built in travertine stone. The city is renowned for its harmonious urban layout and architectural beauty, especially visible in its iconic squares, **Piazza del Popolo and Piazza Arringo**, which serve as central hubs of civic and cultural life. Rich in Romanesque, Gothic, and Renaissance heritage, Ascoli offers an authentic and immersive experience in tradition. Its compact, walkable layout and local identity make it an ideal example of high-quality, culture-oriented tourism, away from mainstream destinations [7].

### 2.3.1 Touristic Situation

Although it experienced a **significant increase in 2024 of +18% in tourist arrivals** compared to pre-pandemic levels in 2019, **Ascoli Piceno still shows clear potential for further growth in tourism**. Among Italy’s 5,014 municipalities available in the dataset of ISTAT (Istituto Nazionale di Statistica), Ascoli Piceno ranked **544th in 2024**, recording a total of **43,873 arrivals**. This figure, while reflecting a notable improvement, remains modest when positioned within the national context. For example, when compared to the top 10 destinations by arrivals in the same year, **Ascoli Piceno represents only 0.4% of the total arrivals of Rome**, the top-ranked city [6].

Furthermore, as shown in *Figure 2.5*, it is important to highlight the **high concentration of tourism flows** among a small group of urban destinations. In

fact, the **top four cities alone accounted for 19% of all tourist arrivals in Italy in 2024**, demonstrating the uneven distribution of tourism across the country. Additionally, **the following six cities registered more than one million arrivals each**, underlining the dominance of a few key destinations [6]. This disparity reinforces the relevance of studying smaller but culturally rich destinations like Ascoli Piceno, which, despite their lower absolute numbers, contribute to the diversification and sustainability of Italian tourism.

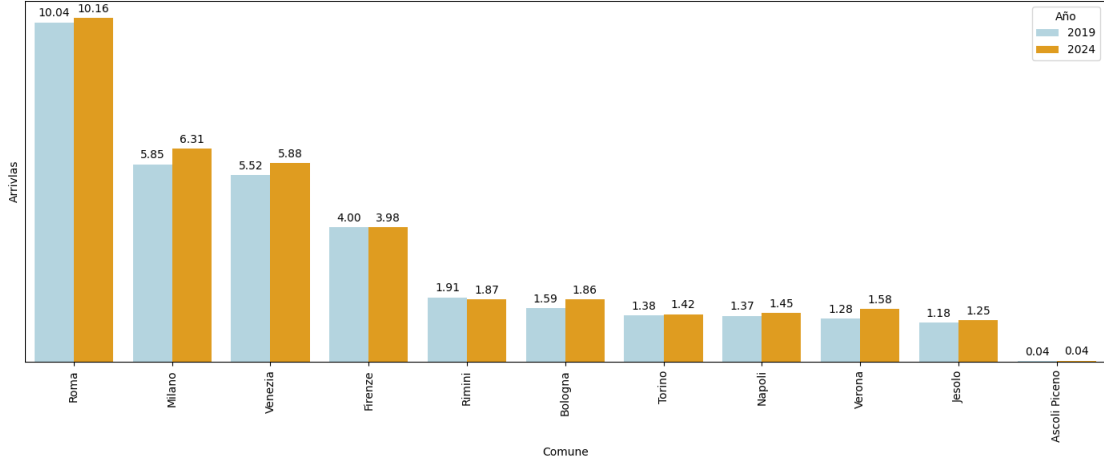


Figure 2.5: Total Arrivals by Comuna (2019 vs 2024). Source: ISTAT.

To better understand the evolution of tourism in Italy over the past decade, the *Figure 2.6* illustrates the total number of tourist arrivals (in millions) from 2014 to 2024 for the country’s ten most visited municipalities, along with Ascoli Piceno. **Rome has consistently maintained its status** as Italy’s top tourist destination, with a **drop in 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic**, followed by a **strong recovery**, exceeding 2019 arrivals in 2024. **Milan, Venice, and Florence** follow similar trends, with notable rebounds after the pandemic-induced decline [6].

In contrast, **Ascoli Piceno remains far below these major destinations** in terms of tourist volume, **never exceeding 0.045 million (45,000) arrivals** in any given year. This highlights its marginal role in the Italian tourism market, despite its rich cultural and historical appeal. This gap highlights the need to explore what types of tourists might be interested in discovering lesser-known destinations like Ascoli Piceno, and how they might differ from visitors to Italy’s more popular cities [6].

The structure of tourist arrivals by residency category (residents and non-residents) shows notable differences across Italian destinations. As described in section 2.2, subsection 2.2.1, of this chapter, overnight stays in accommodations by foreign tourists represented 54.6% of all overnight stays, **highlighting the relevance of international tourism in the Italian tourism sector**. That

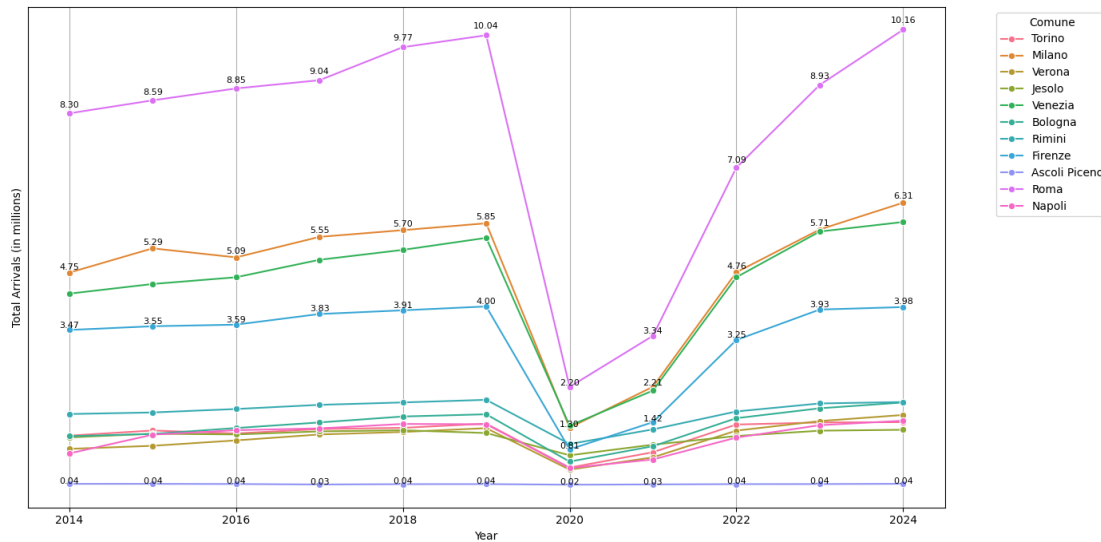


Figure 2.6: Evolution of Arrivals by Comuna (2014 - 2024). Source: ISTAT.

being said, *Figure 2.7* presents data from 2024 for the ten most visited Italian cities. In the **top 4 cities, international (non-resident) arrivals outnumber domestic (resident) arrivals**, representing more than 50% of total arrivals.

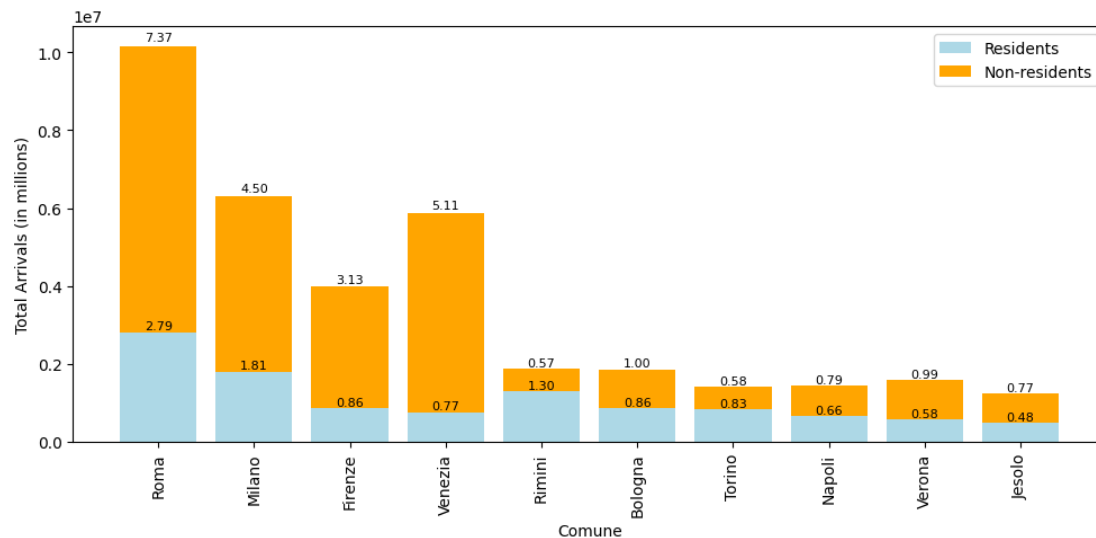


Figure 2.7: Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in top cities (2024). Source: ISTAT.

On the other hand, *Figure 2.8* displays the same information for Ascoli Piceno in 2024. The total number of tourist arrivals is significantly lower than in the top ten destinations. Specifically, **Ascoli Piceno registered 37,709 domestic arrivals and 6,164 international arrivals**, the last representing only 14.05% of total arrivals. The comparison between Ascoli Piceno and the major Italian tourism destinations, along with national-level data, provides a clear overview of the absolute and relative scale of domestic and international tourism flows within Italy.

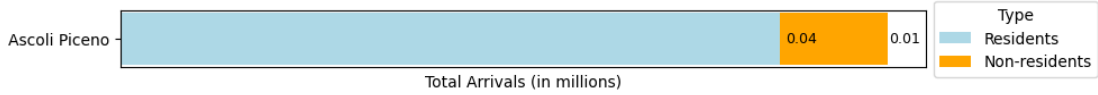


Figure 2.8: Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in Ascoli Piceno (2024). Source: ISTAT.

### 2.3.2 Overtourism: Ascoli Piceno’s Opportunity?

Europe has been called the world’s museum, but its record numbers of visitors have also made it ground zero for **concerns about overtourism**. Among factors driving the record numbers are cheap flights, social media, and the ease of travel planning using artificial intelligence [8]. This matter is something that is not new, and many residents of the affected cities started a time ago with **anti-tourism protests**, even a new wave of anti-tourism protests is being planned across southern Europe later for this summer (2025) [11]. Furthermore, the potential culprits point the finger at each other. For example, Airbnb says hotels are driving the problem, while Tui, Europe’s largest hotel operator, has hit back, saying Airbnb is to blame [12].

In Italy, **70% of tourists go to only 1% of Italy’s territory** [9]. There are several destinations in the country at **risk of overtourism**, including popular cities like Rome, Florence, Milan, and Venice, as well as lesser-known cities such as Bolzano, Livorno, and Rimini. According to a study organized by Demoskopika, Bolzano, Livorno, Naples, Rimini, Trento, and Venice are at a **high-level risk of overtourism**. Following them, at a **high-level of overtourism** are Aosta, Florence, Forlì-Cesena, Gorizia, Grosseto, Imperia, La Spezia and the Cinque Terre, Milan, Ravenna, Rome, Savona, and Trieste. Taking these into account, there is an immediate need for responsible actions to ensure that tourism contributes to cultural enrichment and economic development without burdening future generations [10]. Taking these into account, and according to Visit Italy CEO and founder Ruben Santopietro, **“99% of the destinations in Italy have an incredible capacity to grow”**. Nevertheless, this can backfire, as cities with small populations and little tourism infrastructure can be woefully unprepared for hordes of people [9].

Nowadays, the **sustainable tourism**, term first started to be batted around in the 1990s [9], is gaining terrain in this field. Many destinations are responding with new ideas for a more sustainable travel season. For example, Switzerland’s national train network will be run completely on hydroelectric power this year (2025), as part of its new Swisstainable strategy that aims to distribute tourism more evenly across the country and calendar. The Swisstainable website offers 33% off public transport when booking a sustainability-certified Swisstainable hotel, or 25% off for any stay in a Swisstainable hotel. On the other hand, in Spain they

remove nearly 66,000 unregulated Airbnb listings and pulled back on social media influencer campaigns that bring selfie tourists to its small and easily overwhelmed beaches. Also, they developed a digital platform that monitors how many people are on beaches, as well as the air quality, sea temperatures, weather and even jellyfish in the water. These information can be accessed by tourism offices and hoteliers, helping them (and therefore visitors) make smarter decisions about where to go and what to do [11].

# Chapter 3

## Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological approach adopted to address the research objective. The study combines qualitative and quantitative research methods in a sequential design, supported by advanced analytical techniques. Both the qualitative and quantitative approaches are presented separately [15] and in the chronological order in which they were done.

**The first stage consists of qualitative interviews** aimed at exploring tourist behaviours, motivations, and preferences in a flexible way. Insights from this stage were then used to define the attributes incorporated into the quantitative survey. It also provided additional information that was valuable for refining and deepening the survey questions. **The second stage employs a quantitative survey** to gather structured data from a larger and more diverse sample. This design ensures the collection of statistically significant information while maintaining direct relevance on the attributes identified during the qualitative phase. Since both the qualitative and quantitative research approaches were employed, the field research can be viewed as having adopted a mixed research methodology design, which combines both approaches in the methodology of a study [14].

**The final stage implied the application of selected machine learning methods**, including clustering algorithms for identifying distinct tourist profiles, and classification techniques for describing the potential touristic profiles that Ascoli Piceno could expect, based on respondent characteristics. This mixed-methods and data-driven approach allows for both an in-depth understanding of individual perspectives and a robust statistical foundation for generalisation.



## 3.1 A Mixed Research Methodology

### 3.1.1 Qualitative Approach

The **qualitative approach** relies on non-numerical evidence to generate insights and draw conclusions [17]. Such conclusions are based on rich, descriptive data, including words, narrative and observations, often referred to as “soft” data [18]. This method is particularly suited to the in-depth exploration of a topic and is commonly employed to understand how individuals experience and interpret the world [19]. It allows the identification of previously unknown processes, provides explanations of why and how phenomena occur, and reveals the range of their effects [16]. In this approach, the researcher seeks to interpret situations without imposing pre-existing assumptions or expectations on the phenomenon or setting under investigation [20].

#### Advantages of Qualitative Approach

The qualitative approach seeks to preserve the voice and perspective of participants and can be adapted as new research questions emerge [19]. It is characterised by **flexible design**, which allows the researcher to experiment with different techniques to determine what is most effective within the context of the project [21]. Furthermore, it is typically conducted in **natural settings**, where data collection takes place in real-world contexts or in ways that closely mirror participants’ everyday environments. This facilitates the gathering of **meaningful insights** by listening to detailed descriptions of people’s experiences, feelings, and opinions. Such information can help improve the design, testing, or development of systems, services, or products. In addition, using open-ended questions and flexible approaches makes it easier to come up with **new ideas and discover problems or opportunities** that were not expected at the start of the study [19].

#### Disadvantages of Qualitative Approach

On the other hand, qualitative research has several limitations. First, its real-world setting can make findings **less reliable** because many factors influencing the data cannot be controlled. Second, the strong role of the researcher in interpreting results introduces **subjectivity**, meaning the same data could be analysed differently by different people and the study cannot be exactly replicated [19]. This reinforces the long-standing criticism that qualitative research findings are not verifiable, and verifiability, the principle that empirical investigations should be capable of replication so that their findings can be confirmed or refuted, is a

central tenet of scientific research. It is difficult to replicate qualitative studies in the same way as quantitative ones; however, this does not mean that qualitative research entirely lacks verifiability [22]. This is why it is important for the researcher to carefully document each step of the process, thereby creating an audit trail that allows other researchers to trace and review the original procedures if needed [23]. Third, the use of small samples **limits the extent to which results can be generalised to a broader population**, even when the analysis is rigorous [19]. This criticism may not be entirely justified, as the generalisability of results to an entire population is rarely the primary objective of the qualitative research approach [24]. Finally, qualitative research can be **labour-intensive**, as the review and interpretation of large amounts of textual data often require manual checking, despite the availability of software tools to assist with the process [19].

### 3.1.2 Quantitative Approach

**The quantitative approach** is defined as a research strategy that relies primarily on numerical evidence to draw conclusions [25]. Because of its focus on measurement and statistical analysis, it has often been described as a “hard” or “number-crunching” approach to research [26]. This approach involves the systematic collection and analysis of numerical data in order to identify patterns and averages, test relationships between variables, make predictions, and, when appropriate, generalise results to larger populations. It can be applied in various forms, including descriptive research, which summarises characteristics of variables; correlational research, which explores relationships between variables; and experimental research, which examines cause-and-effect links under controlled conditions. Data collection methods range from surveys and structured observations to experiments and secondary data analysis, all of which require clear operational definitions to translate abstract concepts into measurable indicators. Once collected, the data are processed and subjected to statistical analysis to answer the research questions and test the hypotheses [27].

#### Advantages of Quantitative Approach

The quantitative research offers several advantages, particularly in terms of standardisation and the potential to generalise findings to broader populations. One of its key strengths is **replication**, as the use of standardised data collection procedures and tangible definitions of abstract concepts allows studies to be repeated under similar conditions. This also facilitates **direct comparisons of results**, enabling research to be reproduced across different cultural contexts, time

periods, or participant groups, with outcomes compared statistically. The accuracy of these measurement tools, such as questionnaires, can be strengthened by testing their **reliability** using objective measures prior to data collection [29]. Furthermore, the approach is also well-suited to working with **large samples**, as quantitative data can be processed and analysed through consistent and reliable statistical procedures [27]. The knowledge gained from this group or subset of the population is representative of the entire population under study [28]. Finally, an additional advantage of the quantitative approach is that it is generally considered as a relatively impersonal method of conducting research, which helps to minimise the influence of the researcher’s personal biases on the outcomes of the study [30].

### Disadvantages of Quantitative Approach

Despite its strengths, quantitative research also has its own limitations. One of them is **superficiality**, as the use of precise and restrictive operational definitions may inadequately represent complex concepts. For example, an abstract notion such as “mood” may be represented by a single numerical score, whereas qualitative research could provide a richer explanation. A **narrow focus** can also be an issue, since predetermined variables and measurement procedures may lead to the omission of other relevant observations. Moreover, even with standardised procedures, **structural bias** can occur due to factors such as missing data, imprecise measurements, or inappropriate sampling methods, which may distort the findings [27]. Finally, the quantitative approach can be **relatively inflexible**, as there is little a researcher can do after discovering an error in the data collection instrument. For instance, a question that is ambiguous or has been misinterpreted [31].

### 3.1.3 Mixed Methodology: The Implementation

As discussed in the previous subsections, both qualitative and quantitative research approaches offer distinct advantages but also present some limitations. This has led to a growing agreement among scholars that an effective strategy is to integrate the two. By combining qualitative and quantitative methods, the weaknesses of one approach can be neutralised by the strengths of the other [32].

Explain why I used it (usign advantages and confronting disadvantages), and some important points of the procedure and interviewees.

| Qualitative Interview - Tourism                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Main Questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | In-depth Questions                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| First, I'd like you to think about the last few times you went on vacation to a tourist destination. Can you walk me through the typical process you follow—from the moment you decide you want to travel until everything is planned? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What do you consider when choosing the destination?</li> <li>• Do you look anywhere for help or inspiration?</li> <li>• How much time do you usually take for vacation?</li> </ul> |
| Now, thinking about your last trip — was there anything you did differently from what you just described?                                                                                                                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• If so, was the change for better or worse?</li> <li>• Why did you change or stop doing that?</li> </ul>                                                                            |
| Thinking about your recent trips, once you were at the destination, what did you do?                                                                                                                                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Did you engage in any activities?</li> <li>• Was it a good experience? What did you like or dislike?</li> </ul>                                                                    |
| When it came time to eat, how did you decide where to go and what to eat?                                                                                                                                                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Was it the same for lunch and dinner?</li> <li>• Where did you search for places?</li> </ul>                                                                                       |
| Before we finish, could you name a few of your most recent travel destinations?                                                                                                                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Which ones did you enjoy the most and the least? Why?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                   |
| Finally, is there anything else you'd like to add or think is important to mention?                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <p><b>If the interviewee feels comfortable:</b> Please share your screen. Would you mind showing me how you would search for your next trip on your phone or computer, as if you were planning it right now?</p>                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

Figure 3.1: Guide for Qualitative Interview Questions.

## 3.2 Machine Learning Techniques

# Chapter 4

## Results

Here I'll show results.

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# Appendix

## A. Example of Qualitative Interview from Previous Project

Interviewee's information: 27 years, Female, MSc student.

Interviewer: What are the main characteristics you consider from a place, when deciding your holidays?

Interviewee: I consider mainly the season of the place I'm going. Also I prefer to go to new places, rather than already known ones. Depending on my budget, I'll look a place abroad or the country in which I'm living.

Interviewer: What makes a city unique/different from another, for you?

Interviewee: For me, the experience/tours that the city offers. Historical monuments that I can visit are also important. Taking into account this, also the transportation available to move around and get to different points of it. I also like the food experiences that I may have, so I'll look for specific dishes of the city I'm going to.

Interviewer: Do you prefer being autonomous when looking for things to do/see or rely on agencies and organize activities by a third party?

Interviewee: Depends, if I'm doing a short trip, I would rely on an agency because I have very short time to go to places, so if it is already organized it would be better. If it is a long trip, I prefer to be into the culture of the place, going around, losing myself in the city, so I prefer to be autonomous. Also, if my trip includes more than one city, I usually search some combo of more than one city tour or experience. For example, in Naples I saw some ship experience that takes you to different Islands, or I know that Firenze and Pisa have some convention that sells some pack that includes both cities.

Interviewer: Do you choose tourists packs (accommodation, meals, transport, activities included) or plan out everything yourself?

Interviewee: I plan where to sleep and nothing else. When I'm in the city, I start searching for packs that it can provide me. I look for packs and guides that offer me some city tour, get to know more from inside the city, recommendations

from a local person.

Interviewer: When choosing a spot, do you research its popularity and then decide whether to go or not?

Interviewee: No, if it is a place I want to go, it doesn't matter if other people go or not.

Interviewer: Give me three characteristics that your vacation spot must have.

Interviewee: History/Traditions, Food, Accessibility/Transport.

## C. Qualitative Interview 1

Interviewee's information: Italian, male, 24 years old.

[Interviewer] Can you describe your last vacation? Not so much what you did while you were on vacation, but how you organized it? Starting from home, deciding to go on vacation and the whole planning phase.

[Interviewee] What I usually do is open... I don't know if you know Notion. Yes, it's a note-taking app, let's say, in an organized way. And I create a file for the trip I want to take—in this case, it was Rome. And I write down day by day what I want to do. To do that, I do research online, maybe look for ideas from other itineraries I can find. And then I adjust it based on how much I want to walk, what I want to see, what I'm interested in. But more or less that's the approach, and it also depends on price, how to get there, if I can go by public transport or not, or if I can drive there...

[Interviewer] Describe in detail this Rome trip. So how many days you stayed, what you did the first day, where you found the information... Actually, if you can share your screen, maybe we can see exactly... practically how you searched, also for sleeping arrangements. To see the other options you mentioned, it's really useful. Thank you.

[Interviewee] So, this is the schedule. This is the trip to Rome. It says seven days here, but I think it was actually eight, right? Seven, okay. So for each day there's also the arrival date. In the end I drove, so I didn't have to worry about transportation. As for attractions in Rome, it wasn't very difficult, I mean... it's a very famous city... there are lots of places one can go, so I just tried to make the itineraries a bit organized, so the Pantheon is not too far from Campo...

[Interviewer] So you went by memory for the Rome attractions? You didn't have to search what to see in Rome?

[Interviewee] No, I searched for that too. I looked up "one-week itinerary in Rome". And I compared various ones, but I don't remember exactly which itinerary I used. But I searched, opened Google, looked up "Rome itinerary", or another thing I did was ask ChatGPT to help me compare them.

[Interviewer] So to give you the actual itinerary and maybe see what was closer, what was farther?

[Interviewee] Yes, even though I must say that when it comes to geographical distance it's not very good?

[Interviewer] Oh no?

[Interviewee] I didn't really find it helpful. Sorry, do you hear the noise? Can you hear it?

[Interviewer] No, we don't hear anything.

[Interviewee] Perfect. Yes, like if you tell it "make me an itinerary considering distance," sometimes it gets it wrong.

[Interviewer] It makes a few blunders.

[Interviewee] Exactly. But if you give it itineraries that already consider distance, the ones written by people who actually took the trip and maybe give you tips, then I find them useful—you can give those a try.

[Interviewer] Okay, so you searched on Google and what did you find?

[Interviewee] Well, usually blogs. I usually go to independent blogs, so travelers—maybe families who like to travel and write—or posts on Reddit.

[Interviewer] Families, but were you traveling with family, with friends, alone?

[Interviewee] A friend who hosted me.

[Interviewer] Okay, so maybe it didn't feel strange to take advice from families? Or maybe you thought: "Well, in the end, the things to see..." Or maybe you were more interested in advice from people your age or travel style?

[Interviewee] Let's say what I wanted to do in Rome was a city visit, the cultural side. See monuments, maybe go to a few museums, so I think that kind of trip is very popular, also with tourists from abroad. Maybe, I don't know, nightlife, stuff like that—obviously I would've looked for other kinds of blogs, I would've looked specifically...

[Interviewer] You said independent blogs—why independent? What do you mean? Not affiliated with... tell me, tell me.

[Interviewee] Usually agencies charge money. It's a bit tricky—maybe you find fairly generic itineraries on agency websites. I had to find it myself. Then, I don't know, I get a bit... how to say... maybe unfairly... when I realize it's an agency, or maybe even if it's a supposedly independent blog, when I feel like maybe they're recommending a place not because they genuinely liked it, but maybe because they're getting paid, or they get commission for sending people there. It's not necessarily a bad thing.

[Interviewer] But it puts you in a different mindset, you're saying?

[Interviewee] I sense a bias from them.

[Interviewer] Sure. Listen, do you ever get inspired by images? Do you search

on social media through hashtags or things like that?

[Interviewee] I don't think I've ever used hashtags. I don't even know if people use them. Like I don't go looking for them—maybe it's happened... not so much for Rome, but maybe for mountain hikes or things like that where you get a view... it shows you the scenery. So yeah, it's happened, but I didn't look for it on purpose—it's more something that just popped up, so I got curious and maybe decided to visit it.

[Interviewer] Okay. So you're saying if it pops up in front of me, sure, but it's not a method I use to search—right? Now try to make a little memory effort if you can. Try to imagine when you were younger and maybe went with your parents. Did you ever go somewhere with them? Can you remember how the process worked—maybe your mom or dad took care of it, maybe they went to a travel agency... I don't know, can you remember anything, even vaguely? Obviously not the whole process but anything at all?

[Interviewee] I think so—like yes... but I was really little. They probably relied on agencies. Then there was a period where we did another kind of trip, and it was more based on word-of-mouth. My father also... I mean he had internet access quite early on compared to... like in the early 2000s I think it wasn't that common yet. And even then, back then there were blogs too, though fewer than now. I think he did more or less what I do now, but with fewer tools. But he probably also relied a lot on personal word-of-mouth. Advice from a friend who had the same passions. But yes, surely for a couple of trips they used agencies, though I think only a few.

[Interviewer] Okay, now I'll have you play a role. If you can share your screen again. I'll give you the name of a city. Imagine we're friends and I suggest this city to you... and you show me what process you would follow to decide if it's a place to go or not, if you would go or not. What would you search, what would you look at—photos, text, you tell me. I give you the city name. We're friends and I say "Hey, I think a good place to visit is Ascoli Piceno."

[Interviewee] How many days?

[Interviewer] I don't know. You decide.

[Interviewee] What to see in five days. So... I'd go by car because in winter with transportation... driving is best. So what I would do is check out all these websites I saw. No, this one for example I wouldn't look at... not right now at least.

[Interviewer] Say everything out loud—even what comes to mind. Like "No, ugly," "Nice," "This is boring"—tell me everything that pops into your head. I'm the voice in your head—go, speak!

[Interviewee] Like TripAdvisor! It's really useful in my opinion, maybe for

finding... I don't know... I usually use it more for checking if a restaurant is good, if it's rated well. I'd close it for now in this phase because I wouldn't use it. This site though, which reviews places, tells me opening times, if you need tickets... this is the kind of site I'd look at. Same here, I imagine they're doing about the same thing. And here's ChatGPT giving me more information. And what I would do then... you can't see because I didn't share my screen properly—I only shared the page—but I'd reopen the Notion file from before and start writing notes.

[Interviewer] Okay, but after this quick glance... would you say “Alright, let's go, let's do this trip,” or “No, boring, I'll look for something else”?

[Interviewee] Ah, for Ascoli Piceno in particular?

[Interviewer] Yes, see if I convinced you. I threw it out there—we're friends and now you have to decide.

[Interviewee] Then I also need to check one more important thing.

[Interviewer] Go ahead, tell me.

[Interviewee] How long it takes to get there. Everything counts, so... yeah, it takes a while!

[Interviewer] Have you ever been there? Have you ever looked around that area? Have you ever been in those parts?

[Interviewee] I was in the car a lot as a kid, but I was in a seaside area. So, let's say... the first thing I think is that I feel kind of in the middle of nowhere. A positive thing in terms of, maybe, if you're interested in hiking—though it's not even easy to find someone willing to do it—if I were interested in that type of excursion, I'd say let's go. One element that makes me think ‘maybe I shouldn't go’ is that the town of Ascoli Piceno seems like a fairly small city, and the monuments don't seem unforgettable. So, usually... when do I go to that kind of little village? When there are a lot of them around. So maybe I can go to Ascoli Piceno for a couple of days: visit it the first day, do some hikes nearby on the second day, and then go somewhere else on the third. This type of trip would require a lot of time to organize, also because for sure there are far fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips.

[Interviewer] What do you mean by “there are fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips”?

[Interviewee] Not necessarily that there are ones that discourage these kinds of trips—not in the sense of being positive or negative. Rome, Ravenna... these are more popular places, so it's easier to find more websites of that kind.

[Interviewer] And Ascoli instead... a small village, a little town near other little towns—do you imagine it more or less like that?

[Interviewee] I would only go if I managed to organize—another trip comes to mind that I planned, maybe not on Notion... maybe it's somewhere on Drive—in

Tuscany, where we did a road trip.

[Interviewer] Kind of on the road, going where it happens.

[Interviewee] Exactly, and of course we visited the main cities, the ones you usually include as tourist destinations—Pisa, Florence... but we also went to Livorno, for example, which I would have never visited intentionally if I hadn't been on a road trip.

[Interviewer] So you passed by, saw Livorno and said, "okay, let's stop," right? Not that...

[Interviewee] We organized it specifically to see as many cities as possible in Tuscany. But if someone had told me, "Let's go to Livorno"... I would have said absolutely not. We went to Livorno because it was part of the bigger Tuscany trip... yes.

[Interviewer] And then you went to Livorno—did you like it?

[Interviewee] No, not really. I don't think it's... I mean, we went, we stayed for a few hours, because we didn't feel like there was much else to see. We went to the seafront.

[Interviewer] Continuing that Tuscany tour, where else did you go besides Florence, Lucca, Pisa? Besides Livorno?

[Interviewee] We went to Rosignano Solvay, for example. The white beach... we wouldn't have gone there on purpose, but since we were nearby, it was interesting.

[Interviewer] For example, Rosignano—the beach of Rosignano. Did you discover it while already there by doing a search, or did you look it up before leaving?

[Interviewee] Before leaving, we had the entire itinerary.

[Interviewer] The whole itinerary planned beforehand. And how did you find Rosignano? Did you search something like "beaches," "unforgettable places," or was it suggested by someone?

[Interviewee] Now I couldn't tell you the first time I heard about it. But it's very interesting because the beach turned white due to industrial waste dumped into the water. So I remembered it, and since our goal was a tour of Tuscany, I said, "Let's pass through there, and have a beach day."

[Interviewer] While organizing this Tuscany tour, did you discover anything on blogs—something you didn't know before, but after seeing the pictures, felt inspired to include?

[Interviewee] Yes, yes. There are various little Tuscan villages, I forget their names now... I'm terrible with names.

[Interviewer] Don't worry about it.

[Interviewee] There are these tiny villages, unreachable by public transport. I probably wouldn't have gone from Bergamo to that place. But they were beautiful

places. Even within the overall Tuscany trip, they were a great added value—also inland.

[Interviewer] And you chose them based on images, or reviews you read?

[Interviewee] Both... beautiful images—the Tuscan inland is very scenic, anywhere you go you find beautiful things—and also based on reviews from people who recommended them. So even there, we...

[Interviewer] Listen, I have to ask—since you were in Tuscany, you definitely ate well. I have no doubt! How did you find where to eat? Or did you just stop wherever? Like, “I want to eat Florentine steak.”

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, the Florentine steak... since I have friends who’ve traveled and some who live in Tuscany, I got some advice from them. Then sometimes we just stopped wherever. In those villages, there are very few places anyway—we just sat down and that was it. Other times we searched...

[Interviewer] Have you ever gone to a place specifically just to eat something?

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, there was this restaurant someone recommended to eat Florentine steak at a decent price. And we went there on purpose.

[Interviewer] Since you’re talking about price—going back to Ascoli, from the two images you saw earlier... would you expect it to be more expensive, cheaper, or the same as, say, Ravenna?

[Interviewee] That’s a good question... well... since I’d be going by car...

[Interviewer] Show me an example of how you’d estimate costs—also for accommodation. I don’t know, would you look on Airbnb, Booking... Show me how you’d roughly estimate the costs.

[Interviewee] Usually the first thing I do is go on Airbnb and Booking. I prefer Airbnb for these types of trips, because usually I travel with a group and we like to have one meal out and one at home. The nice thing about going by car is that you don’t need to book in the city center...

[Interviewer] Open Airbnb and show me—you’d look at the Airbnb map, right? Because that gives you a better idea of prices in the area since, as you said, you can drive around.

[Interviewee] Exactly. A bit outside, for example here I see 42 euros per night. And yeah, what I’d do is say, “okay, that’s the price.” It’s true a lot is already booked.

[Interviewer] The fact that it’s mostly booked—does that give you a positive or negative impression of the place?

[Interviewee] About the quality of the place—it tells me nothing. But in itself, it gives me a negative feeling because I think, if I see that many places are already booked, the risk is that what’s left might be quite expensive. So it might be hard to find good prices.

[Interviewer] So, looking at these prices—you put the end of August, right? With these prices, would you think, “No way, it’s too much”? You put three people... no—five people for four nights.

[Interviewee] No, I’d have to check what that place looks like. 35 euros per night, this one, which is the cheapest per person.

[Interviewer] Stefano, I was just saying thanks because you’re dedicating so much time to this—really, thank you. Very kind. So you were saying this is more or less the price. And for food, you said you’ll decide once there, right? I think you said you do Airbnb also to optimize the fact that sometimes you eat in, sometimes out?

[Interviewee] Yes, though... I mean... it’s not even guaranteed. It depends a lot. For example, I might consider staying near a place and only need a few hours to visit it all. So maybe I just pass through...

[Interviewer] You wouldn’t even stay the night, you mean?

[Interviewee] No, I’d go somewhere else—toward the next city.

[Interviewer] Sure, absolutely, okay. So, imagine a nearby city—would you go on Maps... what would you do to see what else to pair with it?

[Interviewee] I’d look it up on Google. For example, for these types of trips... just for no particular reason... maybe “what to see in the Marche,” or in Abruzzo too—maybe we could combine those two regions and decide based on that...

[Interviewer] ...based on a mix of things. So not a single city. Maybe a city fits in because you associate two or three nearby things and say, “Hey, since we’re here and it takes just a few hours to see it, let’s go.” Right? More or less?

[Interviewee] Exactly. I wouldn’t plan a trip just for a city like that.

[Interviewer] Let me ask you a couple of direct questions about the city. Have you ever heard of olive all’ascolana? You know what they are? Have you eaten them?

[Interviewee] I’ve eaten them, even from the place itself.

[Interviewer] So you know they’re from Ascoli? That they’re called Ascolane because of the city? Okay. Oh, you ate them from the place—maybe when you were a kid on holiday?

[Interviewee] No, someone brought them to me.

[Interviewer] Ah, someone brought them—like a friend from there? Someone from the city?

[Interviewee] A friend from the Marche region.

[Interviewer] Have you ever heard of the Quintana?

[Interviewer] Okay. Can you quickly look it up on Google and tell me what comes up and what you think it is? Like if it sparks any thoughts.

[Interviewee] I don’t know... it makes me think of something like the Palio di



Siena, in the sense of: a tradition handed down from the past, something that's stayed around. Then the horses—it seems like a game...

[Interviewer] Is it something that might interest you to see? Or do you absolutely not care?

[Interviewee] Yes, I'd be interested. I think... in that famous Tuscany trip, we also included the Palio di Siena... We even planned it that way—we timed our Siena visit for when the Palio was happening.

[Interviewer] And how did you find out it was during the Palio? I doubt you knew the dates by heart—I don't even know them.

[Interviewee] No, let's say that when...

[Interviewer] So when planning the Siena part, you remembered the Palio and thought "Let's see when it is." You already knew about the Palio, it wasn't something you had to look up? You just knew it.

[Interviewee] Yes, I knew it.

[Interviewer] Alright. Stefano, thank you. You've been really, really kind. Thank you so much for also sharing your screen and showing everything. I really appreciate the chat. Thank you so much.

[Interviewee] No problem. Thank you guys.

[Interviewer] Thanks a lot. Bye everyone. Franco, I'll text you on WhatsApp.

## D. Qualitative Interview 2

Interviewee's information: Argentinian, male, 25 years old.

[Interviewer] There you are. So, first, to begin, please confirm your age for me.

[Interviewee] 25 years old.

[Interviewer] As I explained earlier, the idea here is for personal use only, I'm not going to show the video anywhere. It's simply for later analysis and I'm not going to share any personal information—just age, nationality, if anything. So, to introduce you a bit to the topic, as you may know, I'll tell you the title: the idea of this interview is to talk a bit about tourism. So, to get started, I'd like to know... I don't know if you have a trip coming up soon or not. Do you?

[Interviewee] Yeah, by the end of the year.

[Interviewer] End of the year, ok. I'd like us to pretend you're planning... where are you going?

[Interviewee] To Brazil.

[Interviewer] Ok, you're going to Brazil. Let's pretend you're planning the trip to Brazil. I'd like you to explain to me in your own words: what's the process like from the moment you said "I'm going to Brazil"? Why did you choose Brazil?

And everything up to the point where you said, “everything is ready, the trip is fully planned.”

[Interviewee] Ok, the idea for the trip started with my friends. First it was “What are we doing for the end of the year? Are we up for something? Yeah, we’re all in for something. OK, awesome. Where do we go?” Because of people we know, friends, and other factors, we said, “Hey, Brazil is a good option.” I had already gone to Brazil last year for New Year’s, and honestly, it was a really good experience. So, we decided we’d go to Brazil, because right now going to the Argentine coast, with how expensive it is—it’s the same old thing, and nothing has improved tourism-wise. So we chose Brazil. Then it got a bit more complicated picking a specific destination within Brazil. The original idea was like, “Hey, let’s do New Year’s in Rio,” that was the main idea, New Year’s in Rio, and we started looking into what Copacabana is like. The number of people there, how hard it is to get around, especially during New Year’s—it’s much harder to find good lodging at a fair price. We started to rethink things and asked ourselves, what’s the point of this trip? Is it to relax, to party? What do we want? We said we wanted a mix of both. Then we came up with the idea, like, “Why not do three days in Copacabana and then go somewhere quieter for another... I don’t know, five days?” We really liked the idea, but we realized it might be complicated to arrange transport, find two good places, stay in two different places.

[Interviewer] Where do you search? For example, when you say “we wanted to know what Copacabana was like” or “we were looking for transport.”

[Interviewee] It’s two things. On one hand, TikTok—honestly, there’s a ton of tourist information there, not so much about prices or packages, but more from people sharing their experiences. And on the other hand, I also use recommendations from friends and acquaintances. Some of them had gone to Itamambuca and recommended it to us. We started looking more into it and realized it didn’t really match what we were looking for. And after searching and again checking with people we know, people who went last year, we landed on Búzios. Once we said, “Hey, Búzios is a good alternative,” we started looking on AirBnB—houses or apartments within our budget. Then again on TikTok, we looked a lot into what the transportation is like there, food prices, which beaches are recommended. What happens there on New Year’s, because the main idea was spending New Year’s in Brazil. Honestly, it ticked all the boxes. The lodging we found was well-priced and in a nice area. Lots of people we know are going to be there again. So really, the destination fit perfectly. We ditched Copacabana and chose to stay only in Búzios.

[Interviewer] OK, perfect. And, let’s see, stepping away from that trip... Have you ever been to Europe or specifically to Italy?

[Interviewee] No, never been to Italy.

[Interviewer] And to Europe, in general?

[Interviewee] I went once with school, we went to England.

[Interviewer] Ah, ok. And in that case, I imagine it was a school trip. Thinking more about, for example, a trip with your parents—if you remember—one of those trips, how was the planning process? If you remember, of course.

[Interviewee] Usually, again, we'd start by sitting down and figuring out: what kind of trip do we want to do? A relaxing beach trip? Do we want to visit cities? Something more entertaining? In 2015, I traveled to the U.S. with my family, and the main goal was a Disney trip—Miami and Disney. And it came from that wish we had to experience Disney as adults. And from there, it was a trip we had done many years ago, and we more or less followed the same steps.

[Interviewer] And you're on your computer, right? Could you share your screen, if you don't mind?

[Interviewee] Yeah, of course.

[Interviewer] Great, let's do an experiment. Even though you haven't been to Italy... I'm going to give you a city, and I'd like to see how you'd start planning or researching your trip. Out of nowhere, for example, you say "I'd like to go to Ascoli Piceno."

[Interviewee] What's it called?

[Interviewer] Ascoli. A-S-C-O-L-I. Space. Yes, that's it. Say out loud everything going through your head, what you see—good or bad.

[Interviewee] First thing, obviously, I start by looking at pictures. I think just from the pictures you can already get a sense of what the destination is like. Looking at it briefly, I already say I love it—it's not like I've always dreamed of going to Italy, but it is a trip that's very much pending. What interests me most about Italy is the history, and of course everything that comes with it—architecture, culture, absolutely everything. From what I see, I love it. Anything with beaches is also great; I always look for places that have either beaches or nature. Once I say, "Hey, I like this, it seems like a great destination," what I usually do next is ask around—people I know who've traveled to Italy. I'd ask, "Have you ever been here? What did you do?" If I don't know anyone, I usually go to TripAdvisor. On TripAdvisor, I really like that you get info not just about restaurants but also hotels and activities. Here's tourist information about Ascoli Piceno, and I start looking to see more or less what you can do. Nowadays, honestly, I think one of the main places I search is TikTok directly. I feel like there are lots of content creators who, in one minute, give you a good summary of the destination's essence—what you can do, and give travel tips. But yeah, I find TripAdvisor very useful when it comes to really understanding the destination—like, what am I going to find

there?

[Interviewer] Ok, and for example... if you had to search for accommodation here. You've already looked at TripAdvisor—how would you continue from there?

[Interviewee] What I do first, honestly, nowadays is Airbnb. Mainly because I find that in places like this, it's not worth staying in a hotel with lots of amenities, since when it's a destination like this, the goal is usually to explore as much as possible and you don't spend much time at your accommodation. And sometimes Airbnb offers a cheaper rate. Also, I feel like it gives you more of a sense of "hey, I'm actually living here," instead of staying in a hotel that could be anywhere, like in Thailand. I can find a house that's more similar to the local style. Let's say it was... in August. How many travelers? Two. Ok, and when it comes to accommodation, what I really look at is three things: location, price, and then what the place offers. If I'm staying just a few days, there are things I don't care about—like having a washing machine or a big kitchen with lots of features. If it's only a few days, honestly, just having a microwave might do. But yeah, here you can see it's a pretty central area.

[Interviewer] Also tell me what you think about whatever crosses your mind as you look.

[Interviewee] Sure, this one for example, it shows up as a superhost, has a very good rating. Again, I'm not looking for something luxurious, I'm looking for something that's relatively cheap and that gives me that feeling of "I'm staying in Italy and I can feel it." Now that I know the price and location, I dive into the photos. A fairly complete kitchen. Fridge, bed, room, bathroom... this photo stuff doesn't interest me much. This could definitely be a place I'd stay in. Of course, what I do instantly is check, "Hey, what other prices are there?" Because maybe I see places for USD 427, but maybe there are cheaper options. Well, that's obviously the cheapest, but you have to find something that works for that price range.

[Interviewer] Go back to Google where you searched for Ascoli. I want to see your impression when you search on the map, for example. What does it make you feel?

[Interviewee] When I search directly here on Google Maps, you mean?

[Interviewer] Yes, yes. You're searching and you go into the map to get an idea.

[Interviewee] Well, wait, I had TripAdvisor up here, but there it is. There it shows up. The first thing I notice, honestly, is that I don't see... I don't see any cities nearby that I recognize, which is something that maybe when planning a trip to Italy, one wants to visit as many cities as possible.

[Interviewer] Sorry, what did you say at the end?

[Interviewee] Like, on my trip to Italy, obviously, I plan to visit and get to know

as many cities as possible within Italy. More around the Florence area, Bologna as well, a bit more to the south, the east coast—I don't know much about that. I see it has good road access, a few major roads going through it, so for getting around, that's good. I see it's quite small. I like that it has the Tronto River running right through it.

[Interviewer] And how would you get around here, more or less? Since you mentioned access.

[Interviewee] No, here I'd mainly look at... To get around within the city, I see that it's small, so that's good because you can say "I can explore almost everything on foot," no need for transportation. Now, if I'm staying here for three days and then leaving, I'd rent a car.

[Interviewer] OK, and let's do something else on Google. I want to know what you think because, for example, I imagine since you haven't been to Italy, you don't know what Quintana is. But search Quintana. Let's see what it gives you. Whether you'd see it or not. Go to images.

[Interviewee] The Quintana of Ascoli, you mean?

[Interviewer] But search in images, so you see a variety of things. And just in case, add "Ascoli" to make it clearer. Ascoli Piceno.

[Interviewee] My first impression is that it's some sort of festival. Yeah, it looks like an event. From what I can see, it takes place in the same location.

[Interviewer] Is that something you'd like to see? Is it traditional or not?

[Interviewee] From what I see here, it almost looks like a medieval-style festival, which is cool because it speaks to the local history. From the photos I don't get much info about what it actually is, and that would be nice to understand. Still, obviously from here, if I see it's an event, I'd definitely look into it more on TripAdvisor, for example, or again search on TikTok and try to understand what it is and whether it's worth it.

[Interviewer] And another thing, type in the search bar, also in images: "oliva ascolane." Let's see what it makes you feel, if it's something you'd eat.

[Interviewee] Ok, it's tuna?

[Interviewer] It's meat with... inside an olive, and it's fried.

[Interviewee] Yeah, yeah, I'd definitely eat that.

[Interviewer] And speaking of food—for example, when you're on your trips and it comes to deciding where to eat, since food is such an important part of traveling—how do you decide? Is it in the moment? Do you plan it ahead?

[Interviewee] Yeah, I like to go and at least know of a few places—maybe food tourism spots with more traditional dishes that I need to try or visit.

[Interviewer] And where do you search for that?

[Interviewee] TripAdvisor is usually one of the best places. TikTok again—it's

amazing how much info there is on TikTok. And then, when I'm already there, I also like opening Google, searching for restaurants, reading reviews, ratings, opinions, checking menu photos. And leaving some things to chance.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. And well, just to wrap up—I don't want to take up too much of your time—type in the search bar, but on general search, not just images: "Ascoli," so you can look a bit and compare it with Pistoia, another city. Search both and let me know what you think.

[Interviewee] Should I search? Like this?

[Interviewer] Yes, Piceno. No, Piceno is the same. Just search and hit Enter, see what comes up, and take a quick look. Compare it to another city. Open another tab so you have both open. Pistoia. P-I-S-T-O-I-A. Pistoia. Imagine you're coming to Italy and those are your two options. Compare them and tell me whatever comes to mind.

[Interviewee] Ok. Between the two, I think I'd go with Ascoli. It has a lot of that architectural and historical vibe, all that greenery gives me more of a small-town feeling. Maybe this one (Pistoia), although I'm usually into this style, it reminds me a lot of Game of Thrones. I look at it and say "hey, it's nice," but it doesn't call me as much as Ascoli, for example. Even if it costs almost double... that's something I'd obviously have to consider too.

[Interviewer] Ok. And anything else? I don't know, if you want to search something else or would you make your decision based on that?

[Interviewee] No, maybe just the location... Yeah, we're close to Florence, you see? Maybe that's what would make me lean more towards Pistoia than Ascoli. The fact that it's close to Florence, which is a place I really want to visit. Yeah, in terms of location, Pistoia seemed better to me, honestly.

[Interviewer] Ok. So to sum up, which one would you choose and why?

[Interviewee] If my goal were to tour all over Italy, I think I'd go with Pistoia. If my goal were more to learn about Italy, or maybe about a small Italian town, Ascoli seems much more interesting to me.

[Interviewer] And you, Valentín Campi, which one would you personally choose and why?

[Interviewee] I'd choose Pistoia, because my goal someday is to go to Italy and visit as many cities as possible. But it's more about the location, not that the town itself really stands out to me.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, that's all. I don't know if you want to add anything else, anything that comes to mind.

[Interviewee] No, nothing really. I mean... again, I think in these kinds of trips, where you have to spend a lot of money, it's essential to first ask for recommendations from friends, acquaintances—so many people from here, or relatives, have

traveled to Italy. And honestly, I think someone's personal experience can tell you way more than a photo on Google. So I think a destination isn't decided in one day, not in one search—it takes months of thought. That's kind of how it is for me. I've been planning a trip for next year for months now and I still haven't decided.

[Interviewer] Alright, thank you. I'll stop the recording now.

## E. Qualitative Interview 3

Interviewee's information: Argentinian, male, 31 years old.

[Interviewer] Okay. Well, thanks, Interviewee, for joining. A bit of an introduction, as I already told you, the idea is to talk a bit about tourism. So, just to get started. You recently went on vacation. So what I'd like you to do is explain that whole process from the moment you decided. The process from when you decide, "I'm going on vacation," choosing a destination, and the whole process until you have everything booked, more or less—how... how does that go?

[Interviewee] Okay. From when I choose the destination. The question would be: what things do I do to plan all that, to think through all that?

[Interviewer] Yes. How do you decide on a destination? Why? Where do you look?

[Interviewee] Well. Perfect. So... the first thing I look at is the amount of money I want to spend on that trip, I mean, depending on the money I have or am willing to spend. That defines or rules out options. Once I've made that decision, I start ruling things out. For example, if I have \$1,000 to my name, that's it. I know I won't be able to leave the country, because that's what a ticket costs. So I'd already rule those out. And I'd start thinking more locally. Or not. Keeping that in mind, but putting it aside, once I know more or less how much I'm willing to spend, I start thinking, at first, about places I've wanted to visit because of, I don't know: internet articles I've read, or series I've seen, or things I like for personal reasons. For example, I watch a lot of Asian culture content, so I'd love to go to Japan at some point, but well, given that first comment about money, that sometimes becomes limited. And once I have that in mind, it's also clear that in my case, like in your case, we're married, so you also need to discuss it a bit with your other half to align expectations. But once I've got those things in mind—money, the talk with the other half, then the things I'd like to do—I start thinking about the trip itself. The way a trip starts is by thinking about the cost to get to that place, or how much it costs. And based on that, I mean...

[Interviewer] And where do you search?

[Interviewee] Not necessarily where I buy it, but to search I usually start on

some typical ticket booking site, for example, in this case Despegar, which is the most common one around here, in Argentina. So I usually search there. If it's an international trip. If it's a domestic trip, instead of looking at cost, I look more at the distance, like, do I want to go to a place that's 1,000 kilometers away, or 400 kilometers, or 200 kilometers. That's the first thing I want to check, to see if it makes sense to go by car or not. Generally speaking, I like to drive. So if it's under 1,000 kilometers, depending on how much time I have, I drive, I prefer to drive myself. If it's more than that or I have less time, then I start thinking about what I mentioned about going to Despegar. Mostly because there are things you don't have much control over in terms of cost, I think. I mean, if it's a flight, there's kind of a base cost. Now, once I've decided on how to get there, that's when I start looking at hotels and things to do in those places. To see if it makes sense or if I can make the most of the trip. An example: Salta last year. I didn't have much time and I also didn't have that much money because I was allocating it to other things. So I decided to go to Salta. So, going to Salta? And the first thing I asked was, how much time do I have. I said, well, I don't have much time, I can't take time off, so it'll be a long weekend. Well, if it's a long weekend, I'm not going to drive to Salta because half my trip would be spent driving there. So then I said, okay, I'll fly. I already had a rough idea of how much that would cost because it's a domestic flight. So I knew it was within budget. So then I went to Despegar. I checked prices there just to get a sense. Then I looked for a hotel. And then I said, well, let's say I do this. In these 4 days I'd go to Salta. Would I have time left over or would I need more time based on the activities I'd like to do?

[Interviewer] About hotels, where do you search? For example, how does that process go?

[Interviewee] Hotels, I usually go to Booking.com, because I'm more into hotels. I prefer hotels over Airbnb because of the built-in conveniences. Not necessarily better, but I prefer having certain things already taken care of. I'd rather focus on where I want to have lunch and dinner than what I'll have for breakfast. For example, what a typical hotel offers is breakfast. You can pay for it or it's included. So you can already scratch one thing off your daily planning. And well, I start to make a sort of itinerary. Lately, I'm all in on ChatGPT for itineraries. I even did that when I traveled to Europe recently, I mean, it's a different scale of trip, but still. Say I knew the things I wanted to do in each place. But the night before, or once I arrived at the destination, I'd write a prompt: "Hey, I'm here. I'm in this area. I'd like a 3-day itinerary with nearby activities, farther ones, touristy things, and local stuff to do." And I'd sort of refine it based on the suggested itinerary. Not to decide the plan, but to refine it and make better use of my time. Also so I



don't go crazy. I tend to over-plan, want to know all the details. And honestly, if you start googling—if you use Google for everything you're doing—I feel like you end up spending too much time with too much information. ChatGPT usually filters out a lot of the bloat, so to speak, and it also starts organizing things the way you're already thinking about them.

[Interviewer] Perfect. If you feel comfortable and agree, I don't know if you're on your computer and could share your screen.

[Interviewee] Yes. What I can't do much is use the mic and this, but yes.

[Interviewer] Yeah. It's just an experiment anyway. There it is. The idea is, let's say I tell you your next trip is already decided. And it's Ascoli Piceno. How would you search? You need to start putting something together—how would you search? How would you plan the trip?

[Interviewee] The itinerary or the hotel stuff and all that?

[Interviewer] Whatever. You know you're going to Ascoli: you don't know anything else.

[Interviewee] Okay. I know I want to go there. Okay. First I'd need help with how to spell it.

[Interviewer] I'm going to Ascoli.

[Interviewee] Ascoli, like that. There it is. Yes, there's Piceno. First thing I'd do then is Despegar.com. I imagine there's no direct flight. In fact, let's say I don't know if there are direct flights to Ascoli Piceno. So I'd look up... literal ways to get to Ascoli. Mostly to see if it tells me: hey, you should take a flight. And then there are 4 ways to get there. Like here, it says the direct way to get to Ascoli Piceno. This is something else I do nowadays. I used to fully enter the websites. Now Google's overview is working pretty well for me. Fly to the airport near Italy and then take a bus or train... to Ascoli Piceno. Okay. So I already know it's a flight plus some kind of ground transport, and it looks like Rome is the closest big city. So I'd probably go with Buenos Aires–Rome. I don't want perks. And let's say it has to be in the summer still. Let's say from the 15th to the 20th... just as an example. One person, yes, I don't care. What I want here is just to get an idea of how much a flight to Rome might cost or even to know... I've never been to Italy as an adult, so I don't even know if there are direct flights from Argentina. So I'd like to get informed just with these things. If along the way I see that, okay, one person is two thousand bucks, that's a ballpark. And I see that here the price range is between 1,800 and 2,600, which I imagine depends on luggage, no luggage, or whatever. But okay, then I know that basically my partner and I will be looking at around four or five thousand dollars. That was the base. I say, okay, let's assume that fits within the basic filter, and I say, okay, then I know to get there, I'd have to do that, and then I'd look up how to get from Rome to

Ascoli Piceno. Just to get a sense. I know it has to be local transport, so I'd look into that. And well, then I'd start looking for bus options or whatever. I'd also ask people I know or places like that. Something I don't do, but my wife does, is travel agencies. She's very used to them because her family always traveled that way. And they even have an agency that doesn't charge you for using it—they get paid from the services for their work, in a way.

[Interviewer] So they plan everything, basically. Okay.

[Interviewee] Exactly... or you can even tell them how much you want them to plan. But for example, this would be a typical case where at minimum I'd contact them, at least to ask "Hey, I need to go to this place. Do you have experience with this? Have you ever done it?" And maybe they already handle part of that route for me. Just to understand it, knowing honestly that they don't charge me extra, but at most, they'll pick services that are aligned with them because they get a referral fee. But okay, that's the transportation plan. Next thing I'd do is hotel. And as I told you, that would be Booking.com. I'd literally go to Booking.com. I can do it if you want. Also just to get a price range based on the service quality too, right, like to see if a 3-star place, how much that costs. 4 or 5 stars? How much could it cost there. Especially this place, because I've never been. Let's say we're thinking about September, two adults, so there. What I usually do is search. And this is kind of a personal preference. The first thing I want to see is if I see a well-rated place, how much that might cost. But then I play a lot with maximums and minimums, like, the usual thing I do is this. I sort by the most expensive, let's say I've got money to burn, and it makes sense, well let's see how much that costs. Obviously I'd rule things out like this, because this isn't for 2 people, it's for 20. But if I find something that fits what I'm looking for. Again. Three beds, like I don't know why, because they're apartments, I think, but if I found something that matches the size I'm looking for. No, I'm looking for a hotel room. I'm not looking for all this. Then I'd start looking at the most expensive price, and I'd do the same with the cheapest. Although generally I'm not too stingy with accommodations, because I feel like if you're not comfortable where you're staying, all your days start off badly. So well, I'd check that. From what I see here, it ranges from 1,200,000 to 400. So, I don't know. I know that if I really wanted to save, here, I could save 60

[Interviewer] Perfect, and let's do something—since you're talking about distance, about renting a car... open Google Maps real quick. Let's see. And search for Ascoli. So you can get a sense of where it is. And tell me whatever comes to mind when you see the city.

[Interviewee] I mean, I already know it's a place where I'd probably struggle a bit, because I can tell the topography looks mountainous. And I have vertigo. So

I'd probably need to be a little careful if I'm driving myself. But if it weren't for that, the first thing I see is that... I don't want to sound anti-city, but it seems like a small place, so having a car inside Ascoli Piceno itself seems kind of unnecessary. From what I see, it's not the kind of place where you need a car to get around. But it seems like a typical place where you'd want to set up a base and then do some kind of excursions to nearby spots. That's what I'd look for. For example, I don't know how far it is from Ascoli Piceno to the coast—we can check. Ascoli Piceno and let's say Villa Rossi. I don't know. Just to head toward the coast. Just as an example. I assume it's something... yeah, but I don't want to walk. Look, for example, 27 minutes from Ascoli Piceno to the coast. I want to believe the coast must be beautiful just because it's Italy. So here, it's very likely I'd want to do this kind of excursion. Before making that decision, though, I'd double-check, because it happened to me... recently I tried to go through Nazaré in Portugal, and I did it with a car. I didn't know what to do, because I had nowhere to park. It was such a tiny place that it wasn't prepared for people to go by car, and I didn't know where to leave it. So, for example, if I could have done that same trip I did in Nazaré by bus—something that picks you up and drops you off at a set time—I might have opted for that. So yeah, there are lots of things to consider when deciding whether to rent a car.

[Interviewer] That's perfect. And for example, when you're already there, you've arrived. Even though you already mentioned ChatGPT a bit, I'd like to know—put yourself in the moment, you're there.

[Interviewee] Yeah.

[Interviewer] And during the days, when it comes time to eat, how do you decide? You need to get something to eat, what do you do?

[Interviewee] When it's time to eat, I do two things. First and foremost is Google Maps. Restaurants. I look by distance from where I'm standing, and the stars and reviews. I can spend an hour and a half reading reviews. I even go into a review and—like, we could do it now if you want—I sort by worst reviews. Like, I look at top bad comments to see if someone says: “there were rats” or if they're complaining because the meat wasn't cooked enough—which for me are two totally different things. I can deal with undercooked meat. I cannot deal with rats in a restaurant. So I look for that to narrow things down. When I went on this trip too. I didn't expect this, but I also used ChatGPT to tell me the must-visits, I mean, I don't know if that's how you say it, but the “can't miss” places—because I only had 3 days in one location. And I wanted it not to tell me when or how or at what time to go, but which things, if I left without seeing or doing, I'd be in a conversation with someone and they'd say “What? You didn't go there? Everyone goes there.” And I would've missed it just because I didn't

Google it or ask someone. So it'd be those two ways, but the one that wins hands down—the one I also use where I live—is Google Maps, restaurants. And I play around with the Search Nearby depending on the area, whether it's big or small.

[Interviewer] Perfect, perfect. And open... I'm opening a bunch of tabs for you. Open one more tab.

[Interviewee] I don't mind. Yeah.

[Interviewer] And type in "Quintana." I want to see what you think about this. "Quintana sport Ascoli Piceno." If you want, just go to images, no need to enter. It's an event—just want to know if it's something you'd go see or not, or what it makes you feel.

[Interviewee] Well, this... literally, when I go to a place, especially if it's a relatively small one that probably has some cultural anchor—like many places in Europe or regional spots in Europe, they usually have a central theme, like: "This is... people come here for this." If this falls into that category, I'd probably go—not because I always wanted to see it, but because it might be one of those things that you have to see. Like in Porto—I went to Porto, I don't like port wine, like I can drink it, but I don't enjoy it. But someone said, "This is the oldest winery of such-and-such, with five different presidents." So, I went. If this fell into that category, I'd go. I'll be honest, I'd need to read a bit more. The only thing I might not do, because it makes me uncomfortable, is if it's something like in Spain where they kill bulls or whatever. That's not something I'd go watch. I see horses, so it looks like races or things like that, but yeah, I'd go. It reminds me of one time I went to Tandil and I went to the salami festival, where they were literally showing off the longest salami in Tandil. If you tell me here in the capital, "Hey, there's a salami festival," I probably won't go. But if it's something regional, and the whole town gathers once a year to see it—then yeah, I'd probably go. Yeah.

[Interviewer] And now in the search bar, like right there, erase that and type: "Olive. Ve corta. Ascolane." Let's see if it's something you'd eat. Would it tempt you or not? We're talking about traditional food. From there.

[Interviewee] Since it's traditional food, I'd try it 100

[Interviewer] Perfect. And let's do one last thing, just to wrap it up so I don't take up too much of your time.

[Interviewee] No, no. One thing I didn't forget: if it's something they serve there, if I saw it on a menu and didn't realize it was regional, I don't know if I'd order it. It's not like I'm being weird, but if I go somewhere, I want to try the local things, or see the local things. Sorry, go ahead with your question.

[Interviewer] Perfect. No, no. Cut me off if you need to. This is your space—I need you to talk more than I do. Now I was going to ask you for a comparison, like... imagine that right now you're not going to Ascoli yet—you're choosing

between two possible destinations in Italy. One is going to Ascoli—leave that tab open if you want—and search for photos, whatever, of Ascoli Piceno. And the other one is Pistoia. Pistoia. Same thing, as if you were analyzing it. Tell me everything that comes to mind—positive, negative. And what would you decide... which one would you go to and why?

[Interviewee] Ascoli. The first thing I'd do is check photos, because I'm way more excited about a mix of city and coast—or water or scenic natural stuff—than just city. Pistoia feels a lot more urban to me. Or at least that's how it looks in the photos. Obviously, getting informed would be better, but from what I see in the pictures... look, just on Google Images—here's Pistoia, and there are like 2 green shots. And if you do the same for Ascoli, you see five or six green places, water... it feels like it has way more nature. Not because I'm looking for nature, but that combo is really appealing to me. That'd be one thing. The other thing I'd check is how hard it is to get from one place to the other. I was surprised earlier by what we saw from Rome and then a bus. If I searched the same for Pistoia and you had to take the 63, and then get off, wait for the 70, and then get off and wait for the 130... I think I'd end up going to Ascoli because I'd be kind of put off by how hard it is to get to a place. That could be something that discourages me—especially when I'm starting from scratch. Keep in mind that in neither of the two did I already have something I was looking for—they're both new. And another thing—sorry to go back to ChatGPT, but I'm kind of obsessed with it right now—I'd make a list of the top 10 things to do in each one. And I'd see if one of the two lists has more stuff I like than the other. For example, if Pistoia says, "Look, this is the best place to go because it has the Museum of Modern Art." But then Ascoli says, "Best place to go for food and wine." I'm way more into wine and food than modern art museums, or whatever that example was. So I'd use that to eliminate or shortlist places. Reality is that both are in Italy, so cultural comfort wouldn't vary much for me. But that would also be something to consider. Like, if you compared Turkey and Italy, then maybe I'd be thinking, "Culturally..." also thinking about my wife, who sometimes struggles more with things that are really unfamiliar to her. Like I mentioned Japan and Asia earlier—that's still something I'm trying to convince her about... I guess because she just can't picture herself there. So yeah, that would factor into the mix too. I'll summarize what I said to make your life easier...

[Interviewer] No, no, it's fine. That was perfectly clear. And for example, bring up the map of Pistoia—you already saw Ascoli's—it's on the east side. Pull up Pistoia now, since you were talking about distances, and that comparison is helpful.

[Interviewee] Look. Actually, it looks more like a city just from how it's laid

out, while the other one looks like a sausage in the middle of the mountains. But sorry, what was the question again?

[Interviewer] No, just to add to the comparison. And also so you can wrap it up by telling me, I'd prefer this one: which of the two cities would you choose?

[Interviewee] I'll tell you right now—I don't remember what I searched about Ascoli. Well, the fact that the Leaning Tower of Pisa is nearby means it's way easier to get to Pistoia. It seems like Ascoli... actually, we saw earlier that Rome was the likely access point. So it might be more complicated to get there. Still, if there's something that attracts me, it's being near that coast, which seems like it'd be a bit more peaceful in a way. I imagine—though I've never been to Italy—that this coast is busier than the other one, just because of its proximity to Rome. If my trip were... if I wanted to do more of a nature-based thing—not just nature there, but being close to the coast, water, and so on—I'd definitely go here. If my trip were like “Hey, I want to go to Rome, but also visit some places a bit farther from the city to see something more authentic,” then I'd go with this one. I think proximity to the airport could make a difference.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, that's all from my side. I don't know if you have anything else to add—otherwise, we're good to wrap up.

[Interviewee] I'm thinking... but I don't think so.

[Interviewer] Perfect.

## F. Qualitative Interview 4

Interviewee's information: Spanish, male, 25 years old.

[Interviewer] Well, first to let you know that I'm not going to circulate or share this recording with anyone. It's just for me, to later review everything we talked about. To remember and record your age.

[Interviewee] 25. Yes.

[Interviewer] 25 and you're from Spain. Perfect. That's all. I don't need names or anything. Well, as I mentioned a bit, this is about tourism. So the idea is that you speak more than I do. I'll ask questions, but it's your space. And to begin, I want to ask if you have any trip in mind coming up soon. Any trip anywhere.

[Interviewee] Yes, yes. In fact, I'm going to Menorca from August 8 to 11, with some friends from university.

[Interviewer] Perfect. So I ask that—you may or may not have finalized everything—explain to me the whole process from when you decided “hey, I'm going on vacation” with your friends, until the point where you said, well, we're going to Menorca. And why you chose there, and how the trip planning process went.

[Interviewee] Ok. Well, I'll quickly tell you the story. Basically, we're four.

Right. Me and three more who met at the University of Girona. And basically, the situation is that one of them is doing a PhD in Canada. But he lives in Menorca. He is—let’s say—his house is in Menorca. So since he comes back every summer to see his family and such, and he has a house there, well, he told us he would love for us to come to his house and visit all the beaches in Menorca, which are very beautiful. Also because he knows the whole island, well, for going out and all. And so, talking and talking, well, one day we have a WhatsApp group between the four of us, and he suggested it. We started, then, planning a little, checking like “look, this date works better for me,” for another maybe another one. Until we agreed that the weekend from the 8th to the 11th works for all of us, and that’s it, we decided to buy the flights. One of the four, Alex, bought them, who’s one of the group. Because it was cheaper that way. And that’s it. And from there, the plan is basically to stay those days at his house and have him show us all the beaches, cool places to have dinner, to go out. And that’s it. That’s basically it.

[Interviewer] So it’s a trip that’s already fully planned by this person, this friend who knows.

[Interviewee] Exactly. Exactly. Yes.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And thinking maybe about another trip you took before. When you have to think: where to go, where you’ll stay—anything that comes to mind or you remember from your last trip. For example, how is it in that case—I imagine you didn’t have someone organizing everything—how does the classic process go?

[Interviewee] Right, so like how we had to organize it to decide where to go, right? What places to visit.

[Interviewer] Yes.

[Interviewee] Well honestly, last time, if I remember right—which was, well, the one I most recently remember—I’d say it was Galicia, where we went on a trip with another group of friends. Well, my lifelong friends from the town. And basically it was a mix of searching online and using ChatGPT, obviously. And so, between those two things. And well, me searching, my friend searching, and so on, we made a list of main places to go. And from that list, well, checking a bit like the distance we had from the house we rented to the place to visit, and a bit the online reviews and all that, well. In the end, little by little, we were putting together the plan we had. And that’s basically how it went. And then talking among those of us in the group. Going and voting a bit like, “look, most people are more up for going here because from the Google photos it looks nicer,” or “it’s easier to get to,” or whatever. And that’s basically how it went.

[Interviewer] And let’s do one thing—if you want. You can say no. You’re on your computer, right? Can you share your screen for a second?

[Interviewee] Let's see. Share screen—I don't use this app much anymore. But how do I...

[Interviewer] It should be there at the bottom. Not in the middle. It's like a green button that says "Share."

[Interviewee] Ah, yes—Share. I see it, I see it. Yes, that's right. Ok. Entire screen. Yes. Share.

[Interviewer] Okay, perfect. And now that you're on Google, on the internet let's say. For example, let's pretend we're planning that trip you took to Galicia. How would you search, I mean, to decide like, yes, here, there, or whatever.

[Interviewee] Well. Basically, look, I'd use one of the AIs. One I use more is, for example, Claude. For example, I'd search for this one. I'd say new... Well, new conversation. And basically I'd ask, I don't know... Should I write? Like, do a simulation?

[Interviewer] Whatever you want, whatever works for you. You can type or tell me, it's the same.

[Interviewee] Well, basically I'd have the AI here, right? The interface. And I'd ask it, like, "look, I want to go with my friends this particular weekend to this place, and it's a 3- or 4-day trip, let's say. Make me a list of things I can visit in these 3 or 4 days." It would list different places to visit, and well, then I'd probably also ask, recommend a restaurant to eat at. And well. Once I have the list of the different places to visit and restaurants, then I'd specifically look up each thing online. Check reviews of the place. What people think. And then I'd pick the best ones, the ones that seemed to have the best ratings and looked most interesting. And that's it. That would be the process I'd follow.

[Interviewer] And for example, when you have to decide where to stay—to sleep, I mean—how would that process go?

[Interviewee] Ah, like, to pick the, I mean, the Airbnb? Right?

[Interviewer] Whatever it is you do, yes.

[Interviewee] Yes. Well, that's also super important, right? And it would be a pretty similar process to the other one. The thing is, in this case, ChatGPT isn't as useful. I mean, it's useful for searching things on the internet, but when it comes to looking on Airbnb, then I'd use 2 or 3 different websites—like Airbnb and others that are available. And I'd start searching for houses—well, places to stay for 3 or 4 days that are in the area we want to visit. And from there, well, I'd focus on finding places that are relatively close to a city or a big enough town. So we can go to the supermarket without any problem, which is important. Because of course, in the end, if you go to an Airbnb, you're going to cook for yourself most days. Or a big part of the days. You're not going to eat out every day, because otherwise—you know—you'll empty your wallet. So, I'd do that. I'd look for a



place near a city. That's reasonably priced. And again, with good reviews—of course, reviews are essential. You always have to check them. And that's it, I'd basically do that.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, perfect. And so, more or less, you told me that even for going out to eat you use ChatGPT and Google. Now I'm going to give you another example, but I'll be the one telling you the destination. So, for example, if I tell you that for our trip, everything is already planned, we've already picked the destination. And it's Ascoli Piceno. How would you go about deciding what to do in Ascoli Piceno?

[Interviewee] But on which site?

[Interviewer] Ascoli Piceno is a city here in Italy.

[Interviewee] So, what would I decide? I mean, how would I decide what to do in that city?

[Interviewer] Yes. Yes. You know you're going there, but then, how do you figure everything out?

[Interviewee] Well, it would be more or less what I said before. I mean, in this case, it's a city. So it's more focused on the city itself, and I would ask ChatGPT about the city. What are the most interesting places. Then, also since it's a specific location, I'd ask if there are museums to visit. Also about restaurants there. And that's it. And well, in the end, of course—if it's a city to visit for just one or two days, I'd try to manage my time better and organize things a little more. Like, for example, make sure that at least—like—on the first day, I spend the whole morning visiting a museum. Or in the afternoon we visit a specific place in the city, and plan things out a bit more. Right? Because in the end...

[Interviewer] Look, for example—sorry—for example, open another tab because later I might ask you to ask that AI something. Open Google, in another tab. And type in Google Maps: Ascoli Piceno. Since we're talking about how long you'd stay, I'd like to know—looking at the map a bit—how many days you'd stay there. Type Asco... Ascoli. Yes. Space.

[Interviewee] Let's see. It's called Asco. Ascoli, okay, Ascoli.

[Interviewer] There, the first one. Yes.

[Interviewee] Piceno. It's not this one, this here. That's you. It looks nice, huh.

[Interviewer] That. For example. Look at it. Tell me whatever crosses your mind—positive or negative. Would you go here? How many days?

[Interviewee] Let's see. It's not a very big city. It seems like, I mean—it's like a town-city, more or less. Not like Milan. Obviously. So, look, what would make the most sense to me is: if I wanted to stay, say, 3 or 4 days. Spend, I don't know, 1 or 2 days visiting the city. That would probably be pretty quick because it's

not a big city. And once that's done, I'd look for places around it that are also interesting—like natural parks, hiking routes, and so on. And seeing that it's also close to the sea, I'd also search, like, what's the best nearby town to visit? Where are the best beaches? Again, a restaurant that looks interesting. So what I would do is basically plan—like, plan the first 1 or 2 days to visit the city. And after that, the remaining 2 days would be for visiting nearby mountain areas or coastal areas.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And now that we've roughly said we'll go for 3 or 4 days. I'd like you to ask the AI—and here, yes, I ask that you type to the artificial intelligence—what to do in Ascoli in 3 or 4 days, see what it says, and tell me what you think, what stands out.

[Interviewee] Well, I'll say: "Could you make a plan for 3 or 4 days to visit this place, which is Ascoli, and nearby areas?" Okay. It's generating the plan. Well, do you want me to tell you what it says, or is that not necessary?

[Interviewer] No, just a general idea. Look it over, and tell me what you think. If it's something you'd say "Oh, that's great," or if there's something negative you don't like or wouldn't want to do—or would want to do. Whatever comes to mind.

[Interviewee] Let's see. Okay, morning, afternoon, lunch. So, the first day is historic center of Ascoli Piceno. So it's based more on the typical things. I suppose. Okay look—this seems very interesting. It says there are some natural caves near the city. That's something you don't see very often, so that looks promising. Wow, it looks like a good plan, honestly.

The only thing I would like to know, right? For example, it all seems very nice here, but it's also very important to know the price. Of everything it says you can do. Because, of course, aside from the plan, it looks great, but you'd then have to see what it costs to enter that cathedral or the museum. Or how much a dinner at this restaurant costs. But in terms of planning, it seems interesting.

And then here, on day 3 which is already outside the city... it suggests an excursion to Offida and Ripatrasone. I assume those are nearby towns. And a national park. Well, here I feel like they missed visiting the coast, which is also close by. That's not included. But well, I guess it picks what's closer—more inland towns than coastal ones. But yeah. Good. Ahh: look, and here it gives a budget. That's good. Approximate budget per person, per day—like, 60 to 80. So, the max you'd spend per day is €200, which is crazy. But say the average is €100. Well. For a weekend, 2 or 3 days—€200/€300? Yeah. That could work.

[Interviewer] And for example, go back to... well, in the map, right? If you want, open another tab and search another map. Leave Ascoli Piceno there. And type in Pistoia. Let's say that instead of having decided to go to Ascoli, you have two options. You know you want to go to one of these two, and you're not sure

which. It's Ascoli or Pistoia. Then tell me what stands out about each one and why you'd choose one over the other.

[Interviewee] Well, we could ask ChatGPT too, right? See what it says. But just off the top of my head I'd say the other one (Ascoli) calls to me more, because it's closer to the coast, so you have more variety in the landscapes you can see. Because you're—like—you have a national park right next to it. Because here you can... well, on the other map you can see that here there's a park—a national park—that's right next to it, a whole mountain area, it seems. And then it's also super close to the sea.

On the other hand, on the other map, the other place (Pistoia) might be really beautiful, sure, but it's more inland and, well, it seems like a different vibe, right? Yes, it's close to Florence. So you could visit Florence too. But honestly, just based on first impression, I'd choose the other place (Ascoli), just because it seems better located to me.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And I think lastly, just to wrap things up. Check—if you want—on that same tab, on that same page, search directly on Google Images: Quintana, Sport, Ascoli Piceno. Let's see if it's something you'd like to see, for example. And Quintana... Quintana, with a Q.

[Interviewee] So, Quin... Quintana, Sport, you said. Yes.

[Interviewer] Sport. Ascoli, Piceno.

[Interviewee] Quintana, Ascoli Piceno. What's this?

[Interviewer] Yes. Looking at it—would you go see this?

[Interviewee] This is it, right? Well yes, honestly I would go see it, because I've never seen anything like it. Honestly, it's something curious to see. I've never even seen a horse race or—well, I don't know what it is. I don't know if it's a race or if it's reenacted.

[Interviewer] It's a kind of medieval historical event, and there's a lot of horseback riding and... I don't know if you remember—like in many movies—when they charge with a long lance and hit the target.

[Interviewee] Yes, yes. I'd 100

[Interviewer] And I think that's more or less it. I don't know if there's anything you'd like to add that you haven't told me—something important about tourism in general. Not just Ascoli, in general.

[Interviewee] Well, like, a tip, you mean? Or something I think...

[Interviewer] Whatever comes to mind.

[Interviewee] Well, if you're going somewhere—first, if you're, for example, going out to eat—you should always look at... I think you should check two things: if you want to go eat somewhere, obviously you need to use Google, and the reviews are super useful, right? But two things: One, that the place is full. And

that the people in the place are mostly locals—not tourists. If those two things are true—meaning it’s packed and full of local people—then there’s no doubt the place is good.

[Interviewer] And for example, what food would you eat?

[Interviewee] Well, wherever I go, I always like to try the local food—the traditional food from that place. Otherwise, just whatever’s available there.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, I don’t know if you have anything else—if not... we’ll end the interview here.

[Interviewee] No, no. I’m good.

[Interviewer] Alright, thank you. I’ll stop the recording now.

## G. Qualitative Interview 5

Interviewee’s information: Argentinian, male, 26 years old.

[Interviewer] Well, I’m recording, but this isn’t to be presented anywhere, just to later check everything, for the transcription. Simply, as I mentioned, this is going to be about tourism. I didn’t want to give much more detail just to keep the interview as transparent as possible. To confirm properly, please tell me your age.

[Interviewee] Ok. 26 years old.

[Interviewer] 26 from Argentina. I don’t need any information. I’m not going to share any private or sensitive information. So, to start, I’d like you to picture yourself—I don’t know if you have a trip in mind or, if not, think about your last trip.

[Interviewee] I do have a trip in mind, yes, for February.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Where to?

[Interviewee] To Brazil.

[Interviewer] Great. What I’d like to know is whether you’ve taken it yet or not, but think—or explain to me—the process from when you chose the destination and why. And the whole process of how you started planning that trip, from how to get there, where to stay, all of that—describe the process of how you usually do it.

[Interviewee] Okay. Well, look, I haven’t done it yet, but basically, the decision to travel to Brazil has to do first with financial reasons, and second, with what kind of value we’d get from the trip for that amount. Financially reasonable, so to speak. The idea of the trip is to take a cruise to Brazil. It costs around \$1,400 per person, with my partner. And we chose that type of trip because we believe it’s a trip that includes several destinations in Brazil. We’ll have several stops, and at the same time, we have all the advantages of sailing on an all-inclusive,

where we have all meals included, free drinks, shows every night. So everything in terms of entertainment, food, and drink is covered—and accommodation, of course—is covered with everything the cruise includes. And then all the tourism part in Brazil and the beach is also included in the trip through the 4 or 5 stops the cruise makes in different parts of Brazil. The cruise stops, I think, in Búzios, Ilha Grande, Rio de Janeiro... I think Ilha Bela or another place like that in Brazil. And lastly, it stops in Montevideo, Uruguay. So in this way, we're visiting Brazil in different beaches and cities, where we're given around ten hours or so to explore—10 to 12 hours. And then obviously we have all the benefits of the cruise: 24-hour entertainment, shows, theater, casinos—well, everything they offer.

[Interviewer] Yes. And where did you look? I mean, in this case, it's a cruise, but where did you look for information?

[Interviewee] Well, I saw an ad on Instagram from MSC, which is the cruise line we'd be choosing. I clicked the link and saw that they had prices—or rather packages—that were quite affordable for what they offered, so we decided to go ahead with that. This is also connected to the fact that this year in particular, I'm about to move, and my girlfriend is also working on building her house. So, since this is a year where we have limited saving capacity, thinking about a trip to Europe or another destination that requires a more expensive flight—or one that also requires bringing more spending money and so on—becomes complicated. So we opted for the cruise.

[Interviewer] Well, just as you said, a cruise is something where everything's included. Now, picture yourself on a different kind of trip—one you took here, to Europe, for example. How was the process in that case to choose the destination, and mainly, the process of how you planned the trip—where did you search, what did you look at?

[Interviewee] Sure. Look. The last time I went to Europe was two years ago. I traveled with my uncle. And the idea of the trip was... I have family in Spain. So the idea of the trip was to visit the parts of Spain where I have family, and also to attend San Fermín—the San Fermín festival. So, the idea was... Oh, and we also had planned to go to Amsterdam, to Paris, and a few major cities in Europe.

What we did was, first, to organize the trip in such a way that we had a practical triangle in terms of logistics—that is, in terms of travel. We mostly moved around by train. We used planes very little, and the first destination we chose was Madrid, because flying Buenos Aires–Madrid is much cheaper. That route is much cheaper. And from Madrid, you're kind of in the middle of that area of Europe, so you can easily get to Paris, Amsterdam, or any major European city.

From Madrid, we stayed just one day in a hotel near the airport because the next day we were flying to Amsterdam, which was where the trip officially began.

And at that time we decided to fly because the trains were a bit out of the way, so we flew to Amsterdam.

Then, in Amsterdam, we stayed about 2 or 3 days. And we chose to take a train to Paris, because in Amsterdam—and in the Netherlands in general—the flight services are pretty complicated. You know, there's a lot of... well, it's crowded, and it's easy to get lost, there's a lot of traffic and so on. I mean people-traffic. So it's easy to miss your flight and so on. So we went with the simpler option and took a train to Paris.

And from Paris we went to Pamplona, because by then... France is very close to the Basque Country and northern Spain, so it was just a few hours by train. So we took a train to Pamplona. In Pamplona, because it was San Fermín, accommodations were very expensive. So we ended up staying at a hotel near the airport, which actually worked out well. But yeah. Honestly, it was great. We experienced the San Fermín festival and so on. We also went to San Sebastián. We toured around the Basque Country a bit. And then we spent the last days back in Madrid, where the options are very complete.

Basically, if you picture the map of Europe and look at the triangle we made, it's kind of like a circle. We went from Madrid to Amsterdam, from Amsterdam up to Paris, from Paris across to the Basque Country, and then back to Madrid.

[Interviewer] Yes. And since you just mentioned San Fermín—are you on a computer? On your computer. Can you share your screen? If possible, of course.

[Interviewee] Yes. Yes, of course. Do you need me to search for something in particular?

[Interviewer] Yes, it's like an experiment. I'll ask you some questions and we'll see how... a bit of your reaction and also what you would do in other situations.

[Interviewee] Alright, let me open Google. Not sure.

[Interviewer] Yes. Now that we were talking about San Fermín, I wanted to ask—try searching on Google... type “Quintana” with a Q. Quintana. Sport. Ascoli. A, S, C, O, L, I. Piceno. That, that. And go to images, or whatever you want to look at. Let's see if it's an event you would go see. Or what comes to mind when you see it.

[Interviewee] It's kind of small here, let me try to enlarge it. One second. Not sure why the images aren't opening bigger, but yeah—I get the sense it's kind of a medieval event, right?

[Interviewer] Yes.

[Interviewee] And honestly, I don't know if I'd go see it. It doesn't really catch my attention. The thing with Pamplona was more connected to my roots, to my grandmother—she was from that area. But I think if I weren't Italian or local, and I had to experience this kind of festival, no, I wouldn't go see it. And yes, I

did go see... like I said, I liked San Fermín because of the family tradition. But no, this doesn't. It doesn't really interest me. And the truth is I like San Fermín because of everything that doesn't involve animal mistreatment. In this case, I see they're using animals. I don't really support that. San Fermín is much more than the running of the bulls. People think it's just bull runs and all that, but it involves much more than that. So, yeah. I'm not a big fan of events that include animals.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Leave it there. Leave Google open. Now the idea is that we pretend you already have a trip planned, you know you're coming to Italy, but you're deciding between two destinations. One is Ascoli Piceno. If you want, delete "Quintana, Sport" and type Ascoli. And I'll let you research, explore. And the other option is Pistoia. If you want, open another window, another tab, and type Pistoia.

[Interviewee] Yes. Pisto... Got it?

[Interviewer] So... now tell me whatever comes to mind—positive or negative—about both. And in the end, more or less tell me why you would choose one over the other.

[Interviewee] I have to choose one over the other.

[Interviewer] Yes, you're deciding your next travel destination. And what would you look at—I'm not saying you have to—but if you want to go in and explore, tell me "I'd go here, I'd search for this or that." Everything.

[Interviewee] Can I leave images? I mean, can I search something else instead?

[Interviewer] Yes, whatever you want.

[Interviewee] Done! —things to do in Pistoia. Okay. And the other was this one, Ascoli. And... just at first glance and without knowing either destination, I think I lean more toward Ascoli. I don't know, it seems to me that, tourist-wise, it has more things to see. And regarding images of the city and all that—I like it. I like how it looks. I like how the landscapes look. This bridge here seems very nice. I think there's a fort or something similar around here. And it seems like a kind of medieval city, but at the same time very well preserved, very picturesque. And I think I'd lean more toward this one. So yeah... especially also because when I search "what to do" and the first few attraction suggestions are really generic things you could find in any country—for example, a zoo, a cinema, or something like that—I get the feeling that there's not too much to see beyond that. Maybe I'm wrong, but it gives that kind of feeling—like if the first five attractions are an amusement park, a zoo, or things like that, there's not a lot more to see.

[Interviewer] Okay... and I ask that you go in and view the same cities, but looking at the map. Let's see. Take a look. More or less. And tell me what you feel, or what comes to mind with both.

[Interviewee] So, Pistoia—I understand it’s a really small city. And it’s between Florence and Lucca. I mean, it’s kind of a stopover town, probably similar to Prato. And let’s see Ascoli. Just a sec. Let’s try like this. This already looks a bit bigger to me. Okay. And here you had Florence, so this is further north. This one is more central, closer to Rome. No—look—I like this one (Ascoli) more, even now that I see it, because it’s... you’ve got the sea nearby. I think it’s still kind of northern Italy, if you take Rome as the center point.

[Interviewer] It’s the center, but yeah. Yes, yes.

[Interviewee] Center, yes, but more center-north if you will. Well, the north would already be further up. I’m in the center. No, I think I’d lean more toward this one (Ascoli), yeah, I still stand by my choice. Especially because of the location, you know? It’s closer to Rome, which is a major city. Well, it’s at least closer than Pistoia, right? I think the connection would be much quicker to Ascoli than to Pistoia. And I think that’s good.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And now, in general—for example when you travel, say—picture yourself arriving, for instance, in Ascoli. My question is... the process, where do you look when deciding on accommodation? What options do you check out? And on the other hand, when it’s time to go eat—say it’s 7 or 8 in the evening, and you’ve got to eat—how do you decide where, what, and all that?

[Interviewee] Yes. Okay, well, it depends a lot on the destination, right? In the case of food, if we’re talking about an Italian destination, I’m obviously going to prioritize pasta or some traditional local food. Pizza, pasta—well, anything related to that. And maybe something specific to that place... I don’t know... maybe in Ascoli they serve some kind of tuna or fish that you only find there. And I’d like to try that. Then, just normal food, like in my country.

And regarding the accommodation location you mentioned, I generally look for something near the center. Especially when the city’s attractions or most important sites are close to the center. Also, in many cities it happens that the center doesn’t have anything and you have to go to the outskirts to find a main attraction—but if not, in the center. Especially because it’s usually near a subway stop, or a train or bus station. So you have easy access to anywhere.

Public transportation in Europe—at least in Spain—works very well. And I think in Europe in general too. So I usually get around by public transport. Or walking. So if the hotel is near the center, I’m sure I’ll have places to eat dinner and food variety nearby. I’ll probably also have a place to buy a souvenir for my family, a gift. And I’ll still have a flow of people—it’s an area that I think is safer. So yeah, it’s a bit about that—comfort and proximity to things.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, those were most of the questions. I don’t know if there’s anything else you’d like to add that you think is important but haven’t



mentioned?

[Interviewee] No, regarding location, it has happened to me many times—like, for example, in Paris, where there isn't really a spot that's super close to everything. So you often end up prioritizing staying in the center because it's more or less the same distance from everything, even if it's far. So yeah. I also choose based on that—convenience. And I usually research the area a bit too—the type of area, whether it's a more dangerous zone, or a quiet one, or with a lot of movement, traffic, noise. I look into that too.

It often happens that maybe my parents or someone I know has already been to the city I'm visiting for the first time, so I ask them for recommendations or advice on where they stayed. And the decision often comes from there too.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Well, thank you. I'm stopping the recording now.

## H. Qualitative Interview 6

Interviewee's information: Iranian, male, 25 years old.

[Interviewer] Okay, um, well this recording is just for me, for later analyzing the transcription. I won't share it, I won't give any private or sensitive information. Just for having the record, uh, your age? Can you say your age?

[Interviewee] 25

[Interviewer] 25, and you are from Iran, and, well...As I told you a little bit, this will be an interview about tourism. So, my first question is to ask you. To think of the last trip u did. I want you to tell me and describe me all the process you did. Since the moment you say, okay, I want to go on vacation. I want to go to this place, and why? And on the process that, you need to define where to go, accommodation, what did you look, where, and so on.

[Interviewee] Okay. Hmm... All right, about a month ago... the time that I wanted to come back, uh, from my Erasmus program to Milan.

[Interviewer] I think I lost you. I hear you, like... It's stuck the audio.

[Interviewee] I'm trying... I don't know how to do...

[Interviewer] There, I hear... hear you perfect.

[Interviewee] Yeah, but that... Now my computer just stuck every day. So, I don't know. Do you have my voice now?

[Interviewer] Yes, yes, yes.

[Interviewee] Okay, because I just turned off my VPN. So maybe it just was, like, for... Connecting... Okay.

[Interviewer] Okay. So you were telling me about coming back from Erasmus to Milan.

[Interviewee] Yeah. And, uh, you know, the ticket for going back is... Straightly, it was too expensive. And I decided to maybe... find a way to be cheaper. Like, going somewhere else, and then have a flight back to Milan. And... Yeah, and we just, uh, we... me and my friend, uh, just, uh, look after... look for the flights, or, like other cities in Europe. To see if there is an option, uh, for this... method, I can say. And yeah, we found, like, Warsaw and, uh, Prague. And, yeah, these two were, uh... where our options, because, uh... Uh, and then, because Prague was, like maybe a bit more favor in our mind, like, because, uh, it was more a historic place, a more historic city. And, uh, it had... many more... touristic places that we could visit. Uh, we chose, uh, Prague. But, you know, the main reason that we chose these two were basically, the cheap trip we could have there. Like, even, uh, the food. Or, uh, the price of the Airbnb, the place of living. For this, uh, three-day, uh, trip. And then... And of course, the price of the ticket to there... And then, uh, we decided to go to Prague, uh, with bus. It was 13 hours riding, but I guess it worked. And, yeah, it costed us, like, 40 euros. But, I mean, it was okay, because I had, uh, luggages, uh. To carry, so... I mean, it was cheaper. Any way that's the thing. Uh, so, yeah, uh, these were the basic reasons to choose.

[Interviewer] And where, um, where did you search for, for example, the tickets? For traveling, and... Also, where did you search about the cultural part and the historic places to visit?

[Interviewee] Hmm. About, uh, the tickets and flights and everything, uh, we searched for the flights, uh, we... used Google Flights, to compare the prices. And... for... For the bus, I mean, we checked, like Flixbus website, uh. But that, I guess, the best thing that we could have. Um... And for historic places, I mean... maybe ChatGPT. Uh, for planning our trip, use ChatGPT a lot. Yeah...

[Interviewer] Perfect. Um... For example, do you remember more or less, what did you ask ChatGPT for receiving that answer, more or less?

[Interviewee] I mean... We asked to, like, we ask like this. We are here in Prague for 3 days. From, I don't know, we arrive at 8 AM. We have to go to, for example, the office of the Airbnb to put our luggages, because our check-in is out at 4pm. So we can't go there, uh, to the, you know, our room directly. So... yeah, we... I mentioned all these conditions that we had and, uh, we asked her, uh, we asked it to... plan for us the trip. The whole trip. So... Yeah, uh, we had a timetable with places to go. And... yeah, and then we... after that, we just chose from the list that, uh, it provided us.

[Interviewer] And when you decided, when you choose from the list. From the places you went, something that you remember, the best place, the worst place, both cases.

[Interviewee] What do you mean by best places or worst places?

[Interviewer] Like, from the places you visited, which was the one you liked the most, and which is the one that you say, okay I didn't like it, I wouldn't... I wouldn't come back to... to this... particular place in Prague, for example. If there are, maybe you say, no, it was... average, so, I mean, problem.

[Interviewee] No, I can say the best place, but not the worst, uh, because... I liked it all. Uh, but... best place for us, uh, the castle. They had on the top of the hill, I don't know for sure, you have been there and you know it. Uh... Yeah, I guess that one was the most beautiful one, that I really liked, uh, the place, and of course. Also, the whole, like, it was, like, an old town there, right? All over the hill. And, yeah, I guess it was the best place that we visited. It has started with a historic bridge. And, yeah, it was really cool.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And you told me you were with the phone right now, right?

[Interviewee] I'm not with a phone, uh... what they mean by phone? I'm... my laptop.

[Interviewer] You are in computer or phone?

[Interviewee] In computer.

[Interviewer] Computer. Uh, can you share a screen? If you... if you want? And if you can... oh, of course.

[Interviewee] Where's the share screen?

[Interviewer] In the middle is a green button.

[Interviewee] Ah, yeah, yeah, yeah, sure. The whole screen?

[Interviewer] Yes, or internet, like Google, Google Chrome, for example.

[Interviewee] Because I have many tabs, actually. Okay... now you have it.

[Interviewer] It's loading. Okay. Now, I... I will do a suggestion. For example, we are planning our next trip, and I tell you, okay, we have two options to go, and I want you to more or less show me more... what... what are the steps you... You may do to investigate a little bit more about each place. And then tell me what you think. In the process, when you write, when you are searching, what you think, positive, negative, and at the end why would you choose one over the other? I need you to say me, okay, I prefer this one because this, this, and this. So, the two cities, I will ask you to compare and decide where to go in our next trip are: Pistoia? P-i-s-t-o-i-a, Pistoia.

[Interviewee] Uh, wait, wait. I have a problem here, because I just turned off my VPN. For example, I can't access ChatGPT. Okay.

[Interviewer] Okay. Do you want me to share my screen and you tell me what you would do, and I do it myself?

[Interviewee] So... Maybe I go with DeepSeek. I don't know. Let me see... If

this works. Huh. Why is it Chinese?

[Interviewer] Or if not, tell me more or less what you would do instead of showing. It's not a problem if it is... too... too slow.

[Interviewee] Which one is it? Okay, um, which were the cities you said?

[Interviewer] One is Pistoia.

[Interviewee] Bistoya, like it is.

[Interviewer] P, with P, P-stoia. P, with a P. Pe of, uh, potato.

[Interviewee] Ah, okay, Pistoia, city in Italy, okay.

[Interviewer] Exactly. That would be Pistoia. And the other one, I think that you already know about it.

[Interviewee] Ah, Ascoli.

[Interviewee] First, I... see the pictures here, maybe... And then... It'll be the location... to see if... I mean, which one is nearer to me. My internet connection is too bad, sorry.

[Interviewer] No, no, it's okay.

[Interviewee] Yeah, this one is really important for me, because it's, like, a summary of the city. The overview. Basically, it's an AI account.

[Interviewer] Yes, yes.

[Interviewee] Unfortunately, I can't see the... Map, but I will... choose map, also. And then, maybe... going to... Booking.com, or... I don't know if... That was the name? Pistoia... Oh my god. Yeah, I mean, I told you, the distance to the destination. And... maybe, I don't know if... This works, because my connection is not really good. I just search here. Yeah, to see... the prices of, you know, the place to... Stay. Like, an Airbnb or Booking.com, or any other websites regarding this. And... Yeah, and uh... And the price of, like... This one...

[Interviewer] For example, when you have to decide you are in a place, let's say Pistoia or Ascoli Piceno. And you need to define it's 8 o'clock in the night, and you have to decide where to eat. Usually, what do you do? How is the process? Where do you eat? Where do you search? If you search something?

[Interviewee] Mmm... Yeah, I mean, I ask... like, ChatGPT or anything else, but this one, it doesn't work, I don't know why. I just ask, it's 8pm, like, I'm here in this location. Where should I go? Like, what is your suggestion? Think of... Or maybe if there is someone from there. I go ask... If there is anywhere... It can be going there, like, if it's possible to go there, and it's good. Maybe just show us the place, many even... like, asking for suggestion, any opinion to go. Oh... Yeah, uh, these two, I guess, is more probable thing to do, or go.

[Interviewer] Okay. And for example, um... If you have two options to decide. You decide to go outside, but you have an option that says. A really boutique

restaurant that a lot of people... puts a review, a positive review in Google... in Google, or maybe a local store, a local restaurant, small. Maybe not too much reviews, but they have the traditional food from their place. Which one you... you would choose, and why.

[Interviewee] Mmm... I guess, I mean, I have some criteria to decide based on that. Uh, because I'm not that really rich. So basically, the first things I check is, again, the price. And then, if the price of that, uh... I don't know, the fancy restaurant that you said it has a high rating, or a high, uh... for reviews that are really good. I go with that one, because... as, uh... I'm... on a trip, so I don't want to waste money or time, or even my health. Uh, and something that I don't really know. Uh, so I trust... other people's opinion. And reviews of that, uh... location. So, I'm not that risky person, risk, uh... I don't know what... risk lover person. Uh, to, uh, to go to try... that so-called restaurant that doesn't have. Like, maybe high rate, or... Yeah, maybe this.

[Interviewer] Okay, okay. And, well, from my side, more or less, this was the idea. The questions, I don't know if you, from your side, you have anything else that you say, okay, I forgot this, I think it's important to mention, or not. Do you hear it? Ah, sorry.

[Interviewee] Yeah, I don't know if you're, again, working on, uh, the... like, the time of the year to go, uh, to travel or not. Or maybe... traveling alone, or with friends. I guess... I'm not really sure if... It's be alongside with your project.

[Interviewer] Forget about me, I just want your opinion in general about. Destinations when you decide on that, so forget about what. What it means other things.

[Interviewee] Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

[Interviewer] Um, so, okay. And from the short things you saw from Pistoia or Ascoli. Maybe what... what would you decide? I don't know if you're aware of it.

[Interviewee] Where is the Pistoia? Sorry. And, uh, on the map. Where is Pistoia?

[Interviewer] Pistoia is more or less near Florence. Uh, and Ascoli, I think you know what is a little bit more in the center of Italy. On the East Coast.

[Interviewee] Yeah, yeah, yeah, Ascoli is here. Pistoia is here. Okay, I mean, between these two, I will really choose Pistoia, because it's... much more near to Milan, and of course, it's so close to Florence. Because, for example. I can be, like, one day in Pistoia, and then I go to Pisa or Florence to have more fun there. I mean, this... this is... too important for me, actually. And... I guess because it's so close to Florence, it has a better... uh, like, route by bus, or... uh, train,

I don't know, uh... any vehicle that, uh, we... I can use to get there. And even it's close to La Spezia, this is also a great destination. Maybe if I want to choose a city to go. It would be Pistoia, yeah, between these two.

[Interviewer] Okay, perfect. Perfect. Well, from my side, that's... all. I thank you for your time. Now I will stop recording. And so I stopped share also.

## I. Qualitative Interview 7

Interviewee's information: Spanish, female, 21 years old.

[Interviewer] Okay. Well, the recording is just for me, to later check the transcript and clean it up. I won't show it to anyone. I won't share any private or sensitive information. Just confirm your age so we have it on record.

[Interviewee] I'm 21. I had to think about it, I had to think because after 19 I stopped counting. So I was about to say...

[Interviewer] No, that's fine. That's fine too. Well, the idea, as I told you, is to talk a bit about tourism. I'm going to ask you open questions. The idea is that you speak... whatever comes to mind—positive, negative, whatever—just tell me. You're on your phone, right? Or on the computer? Okay. Well, later if needed I'll use my computer and ask you some things.

[Interviewee] Okay, yes. On my phone, on my phone. Okay.

[Interviewer] To start, I'd like you to think of one of the last trips you've taken. I don't know which was the last one, and tell me roughly how the process was when you decided, "Hey, I want to go on vacation." Where to? And the whole process—from finding a place to stay, how to get there—explain how it went up to the point when the trip was ready.

[Interviewee] Okay, let's see. The last one I did was Croatia, and really all I did was join a group and go... so I don't know if that's very useful.

[Interviewer] Then let's pick another one. Yes.

[Interviewee] Yes, one that I actually planned was Vienna. There we looked for hostels, we checked flights and stuff. It was María and me, so one of us checked, for example... I'd check the airport in Bergamo, and she'd check Malpensa. So we looked at all the flights for different days, and also used Skyscanner, which shows you colors for each date. Like, if we leave a day earlier or later, take a super early flight so we don't have to pay for a hotel and just spend the night at the airport. Like, finding the cheapest way to make it all work. Then for hotels, we looked on both Booking and Trivago, compared stuff, and both of us were searching at the same time. Until we found the cheapest one. Because in the end, we were 4 people, and we didn't really need two big rooms or anything—just one for the four of us was enough. So we were looking at hostels too. For example,

we checked if we had discounts with the ESN card. But none of them had good enough discounts—even with the discount, they were still more expensive than the cheapest one we found. We also checked they weren't super far from Vienna, that we could get there by bus or walking in 15 or 20 minutes. Yes, yes, yes. And another trip we also planned more was Rome. But that one was using convents. So I asked ChatGPT to find a convent where we could stay, and that's it. Then we sent emails to all the convents asking for prices. And we picked the cheapest one.

[Interviewer] And why the idea of convents? Like, how did you come up with that, for example?

[Interviewee] Well, the convent thing was because a classmate of mine from Pamplona who was also in Milan with me told me that he had gone to Rome for a friend's graduation and stayed in a convent. And I was like, oh wow! And that they're called Casa per Ferie in Italy. In Spain we also have them, but it's less common to use them. So there are different convents that offer accommodation. And they're much cheaper than hotels or any hostel. Cleaner and quieter. Breakfast included—also important. So we looked directly for convents because we knew hostels in Rome would also be super expensive anyway.

[Interviewer] And then, for example, in the Vienna trip, or for instance the Rome one—let's focus on Rome, since the idea is to talk a bit about Italy—once you had all that, the activities or visits or whatever you were going to do in Rome, did you plan it ahead of time, before the trip, or did you figure it out when you got there?

[Interviewee] No, we planned a bit ahead. María and I asked—that is, we used ChatGPT, we asked it to make us a list of everything. Then we looked at the map, and based on how fast we walk, we selected by areas. What interested us most, what interested us less. And we made an itinerary. Like, okay, we arrive this day, but only have 2 hours. So we do something near the convent. And yeah, kind of organize based on convenience and time. Because, in the end, tourist activities aren't so much about money—because they cost what they cost, there's no alternative. So we thought about which ones were worth paying for, which weren't, if we were interested enough. Also, there was a day that happened to be free. On Sunday, everything was free. So we tried to do everything that day. But of course, everyone else also wanted to go on the free day. You'd get these huge lines. So we said, okay, let's just go to the paid stuff today. And in the end we went to the paid stuff anyway—even though everything was free—because otherwise the line wrapped around the Colosseum twice. And I'm like, not worth saving 3 euros.

[Interviewer] No, no. And for example, on that Rome trip, what did you like

the most? What stood out to you? And why? From the whole trip, I mean.

[Interviewee] I don't know. I'd say the food. Because it wasn't my first time in Rome, I'd seen it before, so I already had a bit of an idea. So I wasn't as impressed by the sights and stuff. But I didn't get much time to eat good pasta the first time. I went to touristy places and stuff that weren't that great. The second time, though, each of us got a different type of pasta, and we rotated dishes. Let's try them all. So yeah, I think the food.

[Interviewer] And how do you search when deciding where to eat? What's that process like too?

[Interviewee] Okay, for that we'd use a mix of Google Maps and TripAdvisor. We'd look at price ranges, because that's important for us too. Then we look at typical local places—if it's a place that's super renovated with lights and stuff, we already know it's not for us. That's for Americans or other people. Not for us. So we'd judge by appearance—if it's a typical lifelong restaurant. We also had a friend who had been in Rome a few days before, so he gave us recommendations. So between our friend's tips, what we found on TripAdvisor, and what showed up on Google Maps, we'd decide based on what was best depending on where we were, depending on the monuments and everything we had to see.

[Interviewer] Okay. And for example, if I give you two options—you're about to go out to eat—and one is a top restaurant that shows up all over social media, influencers promote it a lot. It's top, very boutique. And the other is maybe a more traditional restaurant, family-run. Not much hype. But it's a local option. Between those two, which would you go to and why?

[Interviewee] Yeah. I'd definitely go for the traditional one. Because, in the end, influencers act like they know everything, but they have no idea. And taste... you can't buy taste. Their followers don't know how to eat. They don't understand prices. Plus, there will be a line. If there's air conditioning, you won't even feel it because the place will be packed. So you'll be dying from the heat, and with so many people, it'll probably smell bad too. I know I'm throwing out all kinds of arguments, but it's true—in summer, standing in a line under the sun for 30 minutes just to eat something I saw in a story? No way. I'd rather be served by a Neapolitan dad who moved here 12 years ago—just to say something. So yeah, for me, I always go for the traditional. I really value culinary culture. I feel that chains or over-promoted places lose that. Not always—some traditional places can also get popular. But if you guarantee me it's a traditional place, family-run, passed down generations, and you see the 12-year-old kid helping out, you know the food will be good. Because in the end, I want good food at a fair price.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Perfect. Well, now I'm going to do an experiment. Since you're on your phone, I'll share my screen—but imagine you're the



one using it. Tell me what you would do. Let me share first. Tell me when you see it.

[Interviewee] I see it.

[Interviewer] Okay. Let's imagine... well, this shouldn't be showing. Hmm. Okay. Let's imagine you have to choose—actually, you already have two options here in Italy for your next trip. They gave you these two cities, and you have to tell me how you'd investigate both and decide which one you'd go to and why. And obviously tell me where you'd search. One city is Pistoia—writing it now. Pistoia. And the other is Ascoli Piceno. So imagine I'm entering both, tell me what you'd do. And I'll navigate for you. Where do you want to look?

[Interviewee] Okay. First, I'd like to see them on the map. Like, locate where each one is. Okay, so it's next to Lucca, right? I was in that area before. Okay, okay, okay. And the other one? Okay, the other one is already below Rome or not? Ahh, no, it's...okay. It's just before Rome. Okay. So I have to decide—like, do I pick one for each—or I mean, do I have to choose between them?

[Interviewer] Yes, you're with your friends and everyone's saying, "Hey, either Pistoia or Ascoli." And you have to look it up and decide—tell me what you'd look for or more or less how your process would go to decide.

[Interviewee] Okay. So let's see. For me, it would depend first on how many days we have. Like, is it a weekend trip or a five-day one?

[Interviewer] You define it. You decide.

[Interviewee] Okay? Well, if it were a long trip, I wouldn't mind that Ascoli Piceno is farther than the other. If it's a short trip, I'd prefer to go to the other one because, since the fast train is quite expensive, I'd just take the regular train anyway, and it would take much longer to get to Ascoli Piceno. So for a weekend, it's not worth it to go that far. Because I'd basically lose a whole day, so to speak, going there and back. But for five days, then Ascoli would be fine. And now what I would do is check train prices and times to see if my mental idea matches reality.

[Interviewer] For example, if I put this.

[Interviewee] Yeah, for example. Yes, I'd look it up on Omio, on my phone, but yeah, same thing.

[Interviewer] Omio. Okay. Let's say we go on Omio. Milan-Ascoli, let's say. We're going in September. You said 5 days, maybe you'd go here.

[Interviewee] Yes. Okay. Perfect.

[Interviewer] And let's say there are 3 friends. If you want, I'll read it to you—I don't know if you can see it well.

[Interviewee] No, I see it. I see it. Okay let's see. What I see is that there are flights—that's important. The flight costs the same as the train. So I'd probably take the flight. And if that's okay, then I don't care which one to go to, because

of course, it takes less time by plane.

[Interviewer] And now I'll put here Pistoia. Milan, more or less the same. I think it was around here, the 9th. This gives you flights—it's not really loading. This one, flights, the cheapest is 93 euros, 1h 10min, bus 117€, in 13h. And the train 92€, almost like the flight. Four hours.

[Interviewee] Wow. Okay, so here I'd also take the flight. And both take the same time and cost the same. So I wouldn't really care.

[Interviewer] Look. No, no, here. Sorry. Here. The one I read to you was Ascoli, just to recap. And this one's not loading...

[Interviewee] Okay, okay. I thought it was the same one. I was like, wow, strange that they cost exactly the same.

[Interviewer] There it is. No. And this one, flights are 457€, five hours. It does a triangle route—Genoa, Pistoia. Bus is 55€, 7h, and the train is 57€, you get there in 2h.

[Interviewee] Mhm. Okay, so I could go by bus to Pistoia, or by plane to the other place. And now what I'd do is choose based on the food. And like the things they have, like, let's see—what do they have? Which is bigger? Which has more historical stuff? And that, exactly, I'd ask ChatGPT—like, to explain the traditional food to me. To explain the traditional food of each. And tell me which one is bigger. And for the number of days I'm going, how much time it would take to see each one.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And since we're talking about food, I'll show you at least the typical food of Ascoli Piceno, something that's very well known, and even here in Milan. Let's see what you think. If it's something you'd eat. They're little olive balls stuffed with meat. And sautéed. Like, breaded and fried. What do you think?

[Interviewee] Oh yes, I think I've tried them once. Yes, yes, yes, yes, yes. They're good. I mean, I wouldn't eat them every day. But they're good.

[Interviewer] No, no. Perfect. And from Pistoia, I don't know that much. Maybe they have... I think some kind of pasta. Yeah, like a typical pasta.

[Interviewee] That looks really good, honestly. But, well, if I went, I'd eat it anyway just to try it.

[Interviewer] And from what you've seen so far, I don't know if you could already decide something, or would you keep looking?

[Interviewee] Hmm, I'd ask my friends too, for example. Like, whichever is faster and cheaper to get to... I forgot...

[Interviewer] Pistoia, yes.

[Interviewee] Pistoia, that's it. In the end, by bus you get there in 2h. Well, 2 and a half hours counting the last 20 minutes from home. That was 55€, so

half the price. We get there earlier. I'd probably go with that one just because of that. Because the other one, yeah, it's 93€, it's double, and yeah, it's a one-hour flight. But you also have to get to the airport 2h early, and then there's the trip afterward to get wherever. So really a one-hour-and-ten-minute flight turns into a 5-hour or 3-to-4-hour trip depending on how paranoid I am that day about being late. There's traffic or a strike, because there's always a strike. So I'd probably go to Pistoia. Yeah, Pistoia.

[Interviewer] Yes, okay. Of course. Pistoia. And for example—for example, I'll show you a picture of a traditional sport from Ascoli Piceno. It's called La Quintana. Let's see if it's an event you'd like to go to or not. And why.

[Interviewee] What is it, like polo?

[Interviewer] It's more like a medieval thing. They hit with a stick. Yeah, it's a traditional event from there.

[Interviewee] Ohh, is it like a festival? Okay, yeah, I might go. Like, if someone told me, "Hey, there's this event in this place," and the tickets are affordable—like, I don't know, 30 or 40€, then yeah, I'd go. But if you told me I had to pay 100€, it's like Formula One—I'm not going to see it no matter how cool it seems.

[Interviewer] No, no of course. Okay. Let's see. I think I've asked you more or less everything. Well, you've been in Italy and got to know it a bit... I'll stop sharing my screen. Maybe the last question from my side would be: from everything you've seen in Italy, if there's any name, any particular favorite city and why—tell me. Or if not, maybe just in general what you took away from Italy—what you liked and what you'd do again, for example.

[Interviewee] Okay. I, for example, loved Bergamo. It's a city that—I mean, architecturally, it's beautiful. The churches inside were gorgeous. Also, I think it's a livable city—the people there... there was atmosphere, there was life, they were Italians—yes, there were tourists, but lots of Italians too. And it seemed like a beautiful city I could actually live in. The food there was also really good. We went to this kind of typical, community-style restaurant, like a big dining hall. I don't know how to explain it. Like a big restaurant with lots of tables, cheap but good. And the food there was really good. And yeah, I mean, I ate well, the place was beautiful, it was clean, and easy to get to—which is also important—from Milan. And I don't know, it also had vegetation, architecture... it had everything. I couldn't find a flaw. Like, for example, we were in the lower part of town—which is supposed to be the ugly part—and we already thought it was really nice. Then we got to the upper part. And it was even more beautiful. So yeah, I really liked it. I think that would be my favorite city. And the houses too, because like, we walked up—we didn't take the funicular. So the houses along the way and stuff also seemed really pretty to me. And yeah, it's an architecture I'm not used to.

And I really loved it.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Well, that was basically it from my side. I don't know if you want to add anything else—like, something important you didn't mention and think would be good to say or not.

[Interviewee] No, I think I've said more or less everything. I mean, in the end, my priorities when I travel, when I plan, are mostly price and time logistics. And when I'm in the city, what I value most for whether I like it or not is... I mean, what I paid no longer matters, because I'm already there. So that doesn't affect my experience. What I value then is the city's architecture—if it's aesthetically nice. That it's clean. And the food. Food is very important. And well, also, if people are friendly. But in Italy, in general, people are friendly. So that's not really a barrier.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Okay, I'll stop sharing now.

## J. Qualitative Interview 8

Interviewee's information: Colombian, male, 41 years old.

[Interviewer] Well, this recording is just for me, to be able to properly prepare the transcript afterward. I will use that transcript later, but I won't share any sensitive information about you. I won't use your name, just confirm your age so I have that on record.

[Interviewee] 41. From Colombia, from Bogotá.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, what I briefly mentioned is that the idea is to talk about tourism. What I'll ask you to start—and here feel free to say whatever comes to mind, give me all the details, positive or negative, whatever you think of. So, to begin, let's say, place yourself in the last trip you took—some tourist destination—and explain a bit how you decided where to go. Why did you choose that place? And the whole process of planning that trip—from where to sleep, how to get there, where to eat. How does a typical decision-making process go for you?

[Interviewee] Perfect. Well, I'll tell you that these processes in general—as you were asking, I was quickly scanning how I usually do it—and I have to say that the process has changed a bit from how it used to be. And it's changed a bit because before I was working. I received a salary. And now I'm a student, right? And I have a fixed budget. So, almost like when I was working, I had a bit more freedom to choose. Whereas now, due to the budget cut, I try to reduce spending. Right? So the first thing you asked was how I choose. Right now, the last trip, for example—and the one before that, and the one before that—I've done based on whether I can travel to cities where I have friends living. So, that's one—today,

in this stage of my life—that’s one of the big factors I have. I travel preferably to places where I can stay for free.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And if not—if you were in a situation where you had an income—how would it have been? The same trip, but with money?

[Interviewee] No, that changes quite a bit—and really changes a lot—because it has to... I always travel for an electronic music festival. I always travel for music. I’m on the other side when I’m working. So I’ll travel for an electronic music festival and, hopefully, that city will also have something in terms of modern art. Those are the two big things a city must have for me. Because they’re my two passions. So, when I was working, that’s how I did it. Okay. An electronic music festival, which usually happens in autumn, summer, or spring—though even in winter... and then I’d choose based on that. Okay, I haven’t been to this city, it looks interesting, it has a good festival, and I can also enjoy its cultural offerings. Now, although I’ve also gone to some festivals, I’ve relied on friends. I’ll go to that festival and stay with my friends who are there. For example, that’s what I’ll do next week.

[Interviewer] Yes. And, for example, let’s say you go to a city for a music festival—do you limit yourself just to that festival and stay there, or do you also say, “Hey, there’s this place nearby, I might go explore too”?

[Interviewee] Yes, yes, yes, I do. I’ve done that too, and I try to explore nearby areas as well. But personally, I don’t like the “Euro trip”—that thing people in Latin America do where they visit 20 countries in a week—I hate it. For me, that’s the worst. The worst thing you could make me do. Because I hate waking up early. I like to sleep. And thanks to the travel I did while I was working in Colombia, I’ve taken my time with each city. And I’ll tell you, I can easily stay in a city for a week and not feel guilty about it. I was in Amsterdam in 2018 and stayed there for 6 or 7 days. I visited everything and also went to Rotterdam, Delft, The Hague. But I don’t feel guilty that I didn’t go to Berlin or Valencia or Madrid at the same time. So for me, that running around, not sleeping, and not really seeing what the city is about—that’s not my style at all. I do move around the surroundings, but only if they’re close and allow me to travel and relax at the same time. That’s how I do it.

[Interviewer] And where do you look, for example—let’s say again you’re not staying with a friend, but you’re looking for a place to stay—where do you search? What do you research?

[Interviewee] Okay. Then I plan—obviously assuming the scenario where I’m working and back in Colombia—so the first thing I have to plan is the time I’ll have available for vacation. So okay, at work I’d get—I don’t know—I had 15 working days, or maybe I said, no, I won’t take the full 15 days because I need to return

to do something important. So with that time window, I'd look at how much I'd spend on the festival. Then I start looking at everything else. Okay, I'll spend a weekend at the festival, 4 days, 5 days, whatever. Then in that time frame, I first look for accommodation in the city where the festival will be. That's the first thing I look for. The easiest. I go to Booking or Airbnb. Those are my two sources. So I look—let's say I don't have friends in that city—so, okay. Booking offers me this, Airbnb offers me this. When I was working, I never stayed in a hostel. Now, a little more. So those were my two options. Then I'd say, okay, I have some extra time, I'll expand a bit. And then I'd start looking at accommodation in the other cities, or if it's just a day trip, I'll go and return to the same place, so no problem. But generally, I always book accommodation through those two platforms. I look at prices. Based on what I like, the quality. If I had money available, I could afford more comfort than I can now.

[Interviewer] When you're already at the place and it's time to eat—I'd like to know how that process works. Like, okay, let's eat—how do you decide where to go, if you go out or stay in. If you go out, where do you search, and what do you look for in a restaurant to say, "Okay, let's eat here"?

[Interviewee] Before—and I'll speak specifically about a trip I took to Peru—it was a pretty great example. It was a very gastronomic trip for me. So when I was in Lima and Cusco, I asked all my friends who had been there before—friends who are really good at choosing restaurants and food—"Where did you go?" "Where did you go?" And they recommended places. Then online, I also looked up rankings: "Show me the best restaurants in Lima," and I'd see which ones had a table available on the days I was going to be there. Because in Lima, in particular, everything is always full all the time. Everyone's going to the fancy restaurants. So whichever ones I could get into, I'd go. For example, La Rosa Náutica was super expensive—it didn't matter, I was working, so no problem. Now it's a bit different. But usually that's how I do it. Also, in Lima, my friends recommended some popular local food places. I also love to visit those. I like what we call in Latin America "market-style" eateries—where the city's real vibe is, where the basic home-style food is, what the laborers and workers eat. I really enjoyed that because I love exploring that kind of food. It's very much the soul of a society. And I've done that in several places. I've done it in Mexico, in Guanajuato. I've done it in Lima. In Colombian cities as well. So that's another way I look for places. I usually go for friend recommendations first. And if I'm already there and it's lunchtime and I'm not near one of the recommended spots, I'll open Google and check the top-rated places nearby—what Google Maps recommends.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. And now, if you can and want to, can you share your screen? Let's do an experiment if you can. Let's pretend you're planning a

future trip.

[Interviewee] Sure, I'll share everything.

[Interviewer] The idea is like this. A friend comes along—not someone who lives there—just someone who says, “Hey, you should go to Ascoli Piceno. I really recommend it.” And now you have to decide whether to go or not. How would you search or decide? Let's pretend you're searching and planning the trip.

[Interviewee] Okay. Right now, I'd use this (ChatGPT). I'm not lying. I'd easily use this. I'd ask it, “Hey, let me see how this place is that someone recommended to me.” What's it called again?

[Interviewer] Ascoli. A, S, C, O, L, I. Piceno.

[Interviewee] That's exactly what I'd type in.

[Interviewer] Let's see what it tells you. And tell me whatever crosses your mind as you read.

[Interviewee] Yes. Well... from the Marche region. It's an architectural gem built... travertine stone buildings give it a golden glow at sunset and a magical atmosphere at night. The museums... this right here. That's enough to win me over. They've got me already with that. The local life and the food—trying the olive ascolane, among others. Cheap. Basic meals. Sounds pretty good. Museum entries from 3 to 10. Like I said, in general the review is very good. What I'd do next is start searching for more photos of the place beyond these, on Google. That's what I'd do.

[Interviewer] Yes. No. Pic... I mean Piceno. That's a club.

[Interviewee] Ahh yes. There's another important thing. Okay. Then I'd look up the train. Let's check Trainline. Let's say I'm traveling now in the summer. €47, leaving at 10, it takes five hours. Some take ten hours, twelve, seven, six, five, five... in general, it takes around three. So actually this one is the best, because it's the cheapest and obviously the one that takes the least time. There's one transfer.

[Interviewer] Okay, and... Right. And for example, I just noticed that the chat suggests two things, and while we're at it, I'll ask if you'd consider them. On one hand, food—olive ascolane—would you eat them? Maybe search for images if you want. It's a typical food from there.

[Interviewee] Have you been there?

[Interviewer] What? There? No, I still want to go. I have to go, because it'll be better to really know it. What do you think of this? Is it something you'd eat or not, and why?

[Interviewee] Mhm. I like it. Actually, I didn't use to eat many olives before. I didn't eat olives much. But over time I started to like them. I feel like that's a food people don't like when they're young. At least in my case. But with time...

I like them and it looks pretty... it looks really tasty and very unique—something I've never seen before.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And then about cultural events—the first one it suggests is the Quintana. Would that be an event you'd go see, for example, or not?

[Interviewee] Renaissance-style with parades, riders, and musicians that transform the city every summer.

[Interviewer] Maybe look it up as "Quintana sport Ascoli"—that gives you a bit more of an idea. Sport Ascoli Piceno. Or however you want to search it.

[Interviewee] Looks great. Now I get the Renaissance part. Renaissance tournament with parades, riders and...

[Interviewer] Exactly, it's the tournament, because it's a sport. I mean, it's kind of a sport—see if there's a picture somewhere. Like, there's a parade. For example, here's a picture. The second one, below the woman. The second one. That's the one—it's a sport. No, the one below. The one that says "Quintana così Ascoli rivive il Medioevo." That one, yes—that's the sport, so to speak.

[Interviewee] Ahh, is it this? Like in the movies. That's awesome. Cool. I'd go. And the other one, what is it?

[Interviewer] No, the other one—mainly it's this one. The other is just Carnival, I think. Yeah, every city has a Carnival. So would you go see it? Would it interest you? Or maybe you'd say, "No, I'd rather do something else." Anything.

[Interviewee] No, I really like it because it has to do with culture. Also, I have so many movies in mind—like the Robin Hood era. It's like they did this sort of thing. I'd go. It seems cool. Actually, there's a movie about this. It's not about hitting a statue, like a dummy or whatever—but it's between two warriors fighting, and one of them breaks his lance, or falls off the horse. I think it's cool. I'd go.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And more generally, since from what you've told me you've traveled quite a bit—now that you're in Italy, out of all the places you've been in Italy, is there a city that really stood out to you? One you'd say is your number one and why? What really grabbed your attention?

[Interviewee] From Italy... let me think.

[Interviewer] From Italy? Yes.

[Interviewer] Maybe you'll say none. That's also an option.

[Interviewee] That's also an option. No, no, there are really great cities. The thing is, I haven't had the chance to spend a lot of time. I haven't seen many. I only know Rome and Florence. But I thought Florence was wonderful. Although, Rome too.

[Interviewer] Yes. What did you like the most there?

[Interviewee] I feel like it's the whole atmosphere in relation to art. That's



really what I liked most about Florence. It's like the city is a great representation of what the country does in terms of art. Its cultural offerings are incredible. And there's so much to do culturally.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Well, from my side that was mostly it. I wanted to know about your process, what you look for. I don't know if there's anything else you want to add—like “Oh, this is important,” maybe I didn't ask, but it's worth mentioning.

[Interviewee] No, I think that's everything. I think that's it. That's generally how I plan my trips. Also, obviously, now that I'm here, it also depends if I'm traveling with someone or if someone suggests something. I'm... I mean, I can easily do it. For example, the festival I was at in Berlin a few days ago—when I was in Frankfurt and Mannheim for Time Warp. My friend Clara was the one who encouraged me. She said, “Let's go to this festival,” and I said, “Let's go.” Next week I'm traveling to Barcelona. I'm going to a friend's birthday, but also to Brunch Barcelona, which is going to be great—it's three days. So basically, it's the same thing. That's what drives me: music.

[Interviewer] Only electronic music? Or are there also possibilities for other kinds of festivals?

[Interviewee] Electronic will always be my top, obviously because it's what I like most. I'd go to other types, but not alone. I can go to an electronic music festival by myself. I don't care if someone comes or not. If someone wants to go, great. If not, I'll go alone, because I've done it and I've traveled alone. But for other types of music and places like that, I'd rather go with someone else. For example, one of you guys.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Perfect. Well, thank you. Let me stop the recording.

## K. Qualitative Interview 9

Interviewee's information: Argentinian, female, 30 years old.

[Interviewer] Same as I said, the recording—I'm not going to present it. It's mainly to check the transcript later and make sure everything is clear, because sometimes it mishears words. I won't share any of your personal data or your name. Just confirm your age so I have it on record.

[Interviewee] Sure, sure. Twenty... oh wait. I was about to say 29.

[Interviewer] Right. 30.

[Interviewee] Yes. 30 years old.

[Interviewer] Perfect. So, I didn't tell you anything beforehand because the idea is that you speak freely from your own experience. I don't want you to worry

about saying what I need or trying to say “nice” things. Just whatever comes to mind. The idea is to talk a bit about tourism, and I’ll ask you open questions. To start, for example, I want you to think about the last trip you took, and tell me the whole process from when you decided to go on vacation—why you chose the place, what decisions you made—and walk me through the steps you took to get everything ready for the trip.

[Interviewee] Okay. Well, the last trip I took was the one... can I speak in first person, is that okay? The last trip I took was the one we did when we went to Europe, with my boyfriend and with you guys. So maybe with Emi, if you need, there will be some similar answers. If not, I can think of a different trip.

[Interviewer] Okay. That’s fine. No, no, tell me about that one—we’ll do something else later if needed.

[Interviewee] Alright. So the process of planning the trip—first we decided the dates based on our work schedules. My boyfriend had a bit more flexibility. In my case, it had to be after some work-related events. So, that was the date part. Then, regarding the destinations—since we were going to visit my sister, that was the starting point. We had X number of days—20 days for the trip. Based on that, we picked the destinations. We wanted to visit a lot of places in a short time, so we went for capitals or more touristy, well-known places. We’ll save the lesser-known places for another time. So, we picked locations based on proximity and timing. Then, what else did we do...

[Interviewer] And why, for example—you mentioned saving the lesser-known cities for later—why is that?

[Interviewee] I could say it was because of my sister’s craziness, but no. Basically, we wanted to visit many countries and different places. So, the trip was split in two parts. The first part was capitals that were within a reasonable radius for round trips. The second part of the trip, when we were already working and didn’t have time off, and we had to travel only on weekends, we picked cities—we were based in Italy—and from there we visited towns or cities that were touristy but close enough to do weekend trips.

[Interviewer] Okay, and for example, let’s talk about...

[Interviewee] Also, the choice was based on recommendations. Since it was my first time in Europe, I leaned a lot on advice from people who had already traveled there and knew what they were talking about. Like, if you have limited time and you’re choosing between two cities, someone might say, “go to this one instead of that one because of distance or what you can see in that time.”

[Interviewer] Did you do any kind of research beyond what people recommended to you? Or did you just follow their advice?

[Interviewee] We searched a lot of websites from people who had already trav-

eled and had tips or recommendations. That, plus advice from friends and family who had already been. And honestly, we also used ChatGPT a lot this time—for the whole organization part—figuring out what destination to do first, which to do later, and within a city, what to prioritize based on time.

[Interviewer] Let's do something. I know you're on your phone, but I'll share my screen and you can pretend you're using a computer. For example, since you just mentioned ChatGPT and all that—I'm going to throw out a city name and imagine it's your next trip, a destination you're planning. You need to decide whether to go or not. You tell me how you would start that process for Ascoli Piceno. I'll enter it and share the screen. You tell me where to go—click here, go here, open this, etc. What would your process be?

[Interviewee] Okay. First, I wouldn't just search the city name. I'd type "What to visit in Ascoli Piceno," to see what kind of results I get from someone who maybe already wrote about it—or something closer to what I'm actually looking for, and not just Wikipedia or some generic site.

[Interviewer] Okay. So tell me—what should I do?

[Interviewee] The first result says "what to visit," but I usually try to skip the first few and see what comes up second or third. That one—TripAdvisor—has like "what to do." But look, the second one says "15 most amazing things to see..." and then another says "Top 10 places..." Sometimes the sponsored ones are good, but they're obviously sponsored. So I click on them as a first guide, but then I try to find people I think have more genuine content—not people who were paid to promote. So I'd scroll down a bit and look for a blogger or someone. Like this one says "All about Ascoli, Italy" and it's not from a site I recognize.

[Interviewer] For example, I click on that one.

[Interviewee] Right. And it looks—well, I can't see it clearly—but it seems more genuine and less like a sponsored post. That too—looking for sites where the person says, "I liked it because of this, I didn't like it because of that. I recommend going here first when you arrive," and stuff like that.

[Interviewer] Okay. And once you've read that, what's the next step? Let's say you've decided you want to go there. What would be your next move to organize the trip?

[Interviewee] Once I've decided to go, the first thing I do is look for tickets and accommodation. Because if I've already made up my mind, and like what happened to us during the trip—you might have a very specific date—then I want to make sure I don't miss out on transport or a place to stay.

[Interviewer] For example, how would you search for that?

[Interviewee] Accommodation—that. For those two things, I wouldn't just use Google. I'd go directly to Booking or sites that are focused specifically on

accommodation, and another site just for transport.

[Interviewer] Let's say we go to Booking, for example. And we say: let's go to Ascoli. Ascoli Piceno. There. So let's say we're going—how many days would you choose, more or less?

[Interviewee] Well, okay. Let's say we're going to Ascoli—I imagine I'd stay for three... depends on what I saw recommended, right? Like if they said, "Don't spend more than X number of days" or "You should spend extra time here." Let's suppose the recommendation was four days. My trip now would have to be—generally I'd try to match it with a weekend, so if it's a...wait, let's go back. Am I planning a vacation or a weekend getaway?

[Interviewer] You decide that. Before this, let me add something—maybe you didn't do it, but most people do. Understanding the...

[Interviewee] Where Ascoli is located.

[Interviewer] For example, this is Ascoli. Let me open the map so you can see clearly how it's positioned in Italy. And now you tell me—would it be a place... how many days would you go for, roughly? Rome is here. San Marino, Florence, and here you've got Ascoli.

[Interviewee] Okay. The first thing I would do is check how long it would take to get there and back from where I'm staying. So first, I'd look up transportation to see how much of my time the trip itself would take. For example, I'm in Milan. So let's say... okay, let's say, for example, like in January when we did weekend trips to nearby cities from Milan. First thing I'd do is check the travel time—how long it takes to get there. Then, if I have 3 days, I'd try to make the trip out as early as possible to have the whole day to explore. And the return trip as late as possible to also get the most out of that day. If I have to get back and start working right away the next day, then I'd see if there's a night train so I could use those hours. But if it's a short trip like this, where I'm going just for a weekend, maybe I can use Friday or part of Monday, depending on when I start work. But I try to leave early and come back late.

[Interviewer] Right. So now that you're seeing this, how long would you go for? So we can search something in Booking.

[Interviewee] It says 10 hours of travel.

[Interviewer] Yeah, more or less—there are other options, but let's say this is what you found.

[Interviewee] That's fine, 10 hours. If I can leave late on Friday, let's say, and get there early Saturday, I'd go for the weekend. That way I have all of Saturday and Sunday to explore the city. I'd come back late on Sunday so I'm back for work on Monday.

[Interviewer] So let's say Saturday to Sunday, right? Okay. How many people?

Two—you and your partner? Let's search.

[Interviewee] Two. Yes.

[Interviewer] And now what—how would you continue? What things would you focus on as important?

[Interviewee] In the search filters for accommodation—two things. That I did on my last trip and I'd try to do again. Aside from a budget—because everyone has one, though I'm not sure what mine would be on this trip—you usually have an idea. What I try to do is, first, look at the location. So, if I find any site or anything recommending, "In this city, it's best to stay in this area," or "Avoid this area because it's far from the tourist sites," or it's hard to get around—okay, I eliminate that. So first, I check that the area is recommended because it's close to tourist spots. And also because if I'm going by bus or public transport and won't have a car, it should be easy to get around, and I don't want to waste time on Ubers or walking super far because it takes 2 hours to get somewhere.

[Interviewer] Okay. So location, basically...

[Interviewee] Yeah, location. Then I'd set a price range for lodging. And the other thing I'd consider—well, in this case, since we're using Booking—whether it's an apartment or a hotel, the type of accommodation. I'd look at the ratings of the place as my third criterion.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And for example, once you've chosen your hotel and you've found one that works—when it comes to deciding what to do, what do you aim to do in a city like this? Or what would you search for?

[Interviewee] Okay, for activities. What I like most is getting to know the place, the historical parts. If there's a well-known museum, I'd try to dedicate part of the trip to visiting it, but mainly I'd focus on the historical spots. Then, obviously, if they have parks or squares, I'd look into those too. But I'd start with that. If they have any kind of city tour—whether it's organized by the city or through a site like Civitatis or SANDEMAN, I'd check if they have local tour guides that give you a general overview of the city. And if they don't, I'd try to research before the trip. What I also did in my last trip, in places where we didn't have guided tours, was use ChatGPT and ask it things constantly—use a specific prompt so it explains the place like a tour guide. Not just visiting for the sake of it.

[Interviewer] Perfect. And just at first glance, if you look at the city in photos—is there something that grabs your attention?

[Interviewee] Well, architecturally, it looks quite... it looks nice. So I'd try—like, I feel like it's a city I'd want to explore with someone guiding me, telling me, "This happened here" or "This looks like this because of that." Maybe there are places or towns that are smaller—I'm from Mercedes, right? Maybe there aren't guided tours every day there. Mercedes is a city in Buenos Aires province.

Maybe it's not a destination where you arrive and there's something to do every single day. But I try to research the city a bit before going so when I arrive, I know what I'm seeing, what I'm visiting. Maybe it's known more for food, so I'd look into where to try the local cuisine. Like when we went to Bologna and we couldn't leave without having lasagna. So that—knowing the local dish and making sure to try it.

[Interviewer] And where would you search for that? That was going to be my next question. You have to choose where to eat tonight—and like you said, you want to try the local food. What would you search for? How do you decide where and what to eat?

[Interviewee] First, I'd see if there are online recommendations. Maybe, yeah. If the city I'm going to is listed on any travel recommendation site, maybe it has some food suggestions. If not, there's always Google Maps. I'd search for restaurants or places to eat. Another good thing to do, if you can, is when you arrive at your accommodation, ask them where to go—"Where's the best local place?" or "Where do you recommend I go to try the best local dish?" I use that—recommendations from local people.

[Interviewer] And for example, if I show you the local food—what does it make you feel? Would you try it or not? Have you tried it?

[Interviewee] I've tried them. And yes, obviously, I couldn't leave without trying the originals. Of course I'd try them. I don't really have issues with trying new dishes—I'm not picky about flavors or certain vegetables or anything. I'd try it first and then see if I like it.

[Interviewer] And regarding where you'd try it—is there anything specific? Like if it's a street food, would you eat it there? Or would you only try it at a restaurant? Where would you eat this dish?

[Interviewee] I'd search—for example, in this case, I imagine it's kind of like fries. So I'd look to see if there's a place known for having the best ones—like, "You have to try these if you're visiting." But if I'm walking around and find a place that sells them, and I don't have time or can't get to the top-rated spot, I'd go to another place that sells them. What also happens is that the most recommended or touristy places aren't always the best or most authentic. So when it's something really specific like this, I'd try to get a recommendation from a local who knows the place and can say, "Yeah, those are great—but we locals go to this place."

[Interviewer] Perfect. That's more or less everything from my side. Unless there's something you didn't mention, something important you think should be added—feel free.

[Interviewee] For planning a trip—yeah, places, food—that's the most important: tourist spots, transport, and accommodation. That's it.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Alright, I'm stopping the recording here.

## L. Qualitative Interview 10

Interviewee's information: Argentinian, male, 30 years old.

[Interviewer] Well, as I mentioned, the purpose of the recording is just for transcription. Later, to clean up the text properly. I won't share any private information. Just confirm your age so I have that on record.

[Interviewee] Sure, I'm 30 years old.

[Interviewer] 30 years old. Perfect. And, well, the idea behind today's questions is that they will be open-ended, simply related to tourism. Feel free, don't hold back or overthink, just say whatever comes to mind and be 100

[Interviewee] Well, it could be the one I did with my friends to Europe, or should I look for another region?

[Interviewer] No. Whichever you prefer.

[Interviewee] Whichever I want?

[Interviewer] Europe is fine, it doesn't matter that it's Europe, it's fine.

[Interviewee] Alright then... let's see. I took a trip with my friends, around 2023. Yes, 2023, when I went to Europe. We were mainly interested in visiting the southern part. So we went to countries like Portugal, Spain, and Italy. The first thing we did before organizing everything was to see what was cheapest in terms of flying in and out. Mainly because the tickets were the most expensive part of the trip. Once we had the entry and exit points figured out, it was about connecting the dots. We booked entry and exit through different countries so we could plan a route going from one place to another. We ended up starting in Lisbon, Portugal. So we started looking at accommodations primarily, and what to do, really. I had found some different blogs. There was one blog from someone in Europe who explained how to travel and get around in different cities and what to do in each, and which hostels to stay in. So a big part of it was checking that blog and seeing what recommendations it gave—where to stay, where not to. We mainly stayed in hostels, so it was about finding the main chains and checking if they were available in multiple cities so we could stick with the same chain. And if a city didn't have that chain, we'd look for another hostel chain that worked. Then we started looking at which cities made sense based on distance. We used Omio to compare if it was better to travel by bus, plane, or train between cities. If we could travel overnight to save on lodging, we did that too. So we planned Lisbon to Madrid, Madrid to Barcelona by train, Barcelona to Venice by plane, then Venice directly to Rome. That was more or less the route, and the last part was by train. And it all came down to what was cheapest for getting from one

place to another. And then, to decide what to do in the cities, we checked blogs with recommendations. We didn't do any free tours or anything like that. We did look ahead to find the major sites.

[Interviewer] You did it on your own? You toured on your own?

[Interviewee] Sorry, what? Yes, yes, we did the tours on our own. We would see which places interested us most. What we did a lot of was checking which historical places, castles, museums, and such we could book in advance, and we'd buy those tickets ahead of time so, for example, we already had tickets for the Sagrada Familia, the Colosseum, and the Vatican... just to make sure we had those locked in. Then we'd plan the day around that activity we'd already scheduled. So we didn't really have time for free tours, because every day we already had something we'd booked.

[Interviewer] Okay, and since you mentioned Rome and Venice—overall, from what you saw in Italy—can you name the main cities that stood out the most, that you liked, and also any negatives or situations you experienced that you wouldn't want to repeat? Basically, what was your impression of Italy?

[Interviewee] Okay, let's see. The city I liked the most was Rome. Then there were several others I enjoyed too, like Venice, Bologna, Milan. I think what I didn't like was that the trains don't always run well. The reality is we had a five-hour delay going from Venice to Rome because the train wasn't working. And they don't give you visibility on whether the train will come or not—they'd say it was delayed half an hour, then an hour, then two hours, and so on, and nobody knew anything. Hmm. What else? Then Rome...

[Interviewer] And what did you like about it?

[Interviewee] What did I like? Well, it has a lot of history, clearly—they're very cultural cities, very rich in culture, especially. The food and all that, tons of restaurants, lots of trattorias. Not so many fast-food chains, more traditional food. Also, culturally, being out on the street—the people are more laid-back, if you will. In hostels, you could connect well with people, and at tourist spots, you could interact with lots of people. There weren't bad attitudes or people who didn't want tourists around. So yeah, those are the main points.

[Interviewer] And you mentioned food—when you have to decide where to eat, do you plan it in advance? Or do you just head out and see what's around? What's your decision-making process when it comes to where and what to eat?

[Interviewee] Well, it depends on the city. Sometimes the blogs we read recommended certain places—maybe for dinner. But lunch was more like grab-and-go meals. So we'd try to eat something simple and cheap at lunchtime. Then for dinner, we'd walk around, see what looked good, and just go into a place that caught our eye.



[Interviewer] Perfect, and where did you find those places, particularly? Where did you get the info?

[Interviewee] A lot from TikTok, social media, blogs. Like in Rome, there was a TikTok that said near the Spanish Steps, there's a place that serves pasta dishes in takeaway containers for 6 euros, and the menu changes daily. So we went there. Or someone would say that a certain place had cheap tiramisu. And people would go have tiramisu for lunch. So we'd go to that place and have tiramisu for lunch. Just looking for the cheapest places to grab something quick during the day.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Perfect. Now, I'll share my screen. Let's pretend you're on your computer. I'll set up a scenario: you're here in Italy—let's say you're in Milan, which you're already familiar with, so that's the assumption. And you know you have two options based on recommendations and research. You've narrowed it down to two possible destinations. One is Pistoia. I'll bring it up, and you'll tell me where to go. The other is Ascoli Piceno. I want you to guide me through what you'd do—where would you search, what would you type to ask about it? Then tell me, based on these two cities, which one you'd pick for your next trip.

[Interviewee] Okay. First, what I'd check, since I'm in Milan, is how much it costs to get to each one—on Omio or something like that.

[Interviewer] Okay, let's go through that step by step. I'll open two tabs. So, we'll do from Milan to Ascoli first. Now we'll look at the info. You tell me how long you'd take for this trip.

[Interviewee] If I'm in Milan, it would be a weekend trip—just to spend the weekend.

[Interviewer] A weekend. So, like from Friday to Sunday? Leaving Friday and returning Sunday. Let's put two people. And from Milan to Pistoia. Same weekend. Two people. It's loading—now you can start telling me what comes to mind, anything positive or negative. This is Ascoli.

[Interviewee] Okay. Right, I'm zooming in... the cheapest would be flying. Let's look at the flights. Okay, direct flights, perfect. Let's check the other city. Okay, same cost more or less, but I'd have to travel by... oh, maybe by train. Not much difference from the other. Okay. So now I know roughly how I'd get there. I'd go to Google and look for blogs or recommendations about what to do.

[Interviewer] Any blog in particular? Or how do you search?

[Interviewee] Let's see if I remember right—La Travellina. Let's see if it shows up. It's a blog that...

[Interviewer] It doesn't come up for these destinations.

[Interviewee] No? Okay. Then I'd just go into any blog that talks about it.

[Interviewer] Alright, I'll scroll. You tell me if any catch your eye.

[Interviewee] Wait—you scrolled past one. That one. Visit Tuscany.

[Interviewer] This one or this one? They look the same.

[Interviewee] Yeah, I think they're the same site. Let's go through it.

[Interviewer] Alright. And for Ascoli, same thing? Want me to check the next page?

[Interviewee] Yeah, and let's open this Treccani one.

[Interviewer] Okay, here's Pistoia on Visit Tuscany... it's all in Italian, but let's pretend you're reading it.

[Interviewee] I'd use a translator.

[Interviewer] What are the things you would focus on the most, for example?

[Interviewee] Knowing what tourist attractions there are, because if it's just one source, I'm not going to go based on that alone. I want to understand what there is to do and whether it's really worth it.

[Interviewer] Let's look at the bolded words. Basically, what it says here is that it's a place rich in churches, cloisters, palaces, museums, and monuments. It was proclaimed the Italian Capital of Culture in 2017. Three... I don't know what this is. Three ancient walls. More or less what...

[Interviewee] Okay. When I start seeing things like this, what I do is mark them in Google Maps. Like, I start saving all the points to make a route of what I'll do in the city. Based on that, I decide what hostel to stay in or where to book my accommodation—if it's close to those points.

[Interviewer] Okay. And here in Ascoli... well, this is a bit... it's an encyclopedia that talks a bit about the history. But it's an encyclopedia, I don't know if that's useful for you?

[Interviewee] No, no, no. So I'd go back and look for another one.

[Interviewer] Let's see, maybe because I think... I mean, there are these options. Otherwise, I'll go to the second page.

[Interviewee] I can't quite see the options, what does it say?

[Interviewer] One is Turismo Marche. The other is Italia.it, and the other is Marche Travelling.

[Interviewee] Let's go with Marche Travelling.

[Interviewer] Okay, these are some images of Ascoli. It has a historic center. It's called the City of Towers. It has a Renaissance square—Piazza del Popolo—considered one of the most beautiful squares in Italy.

[Interviewee] Nice. Yeah, I'd start marking all this on the map—this square, the Café Meletti, what else—the Church of San Francesco, Piazza Arringo. I'd start looking at it all on Google Maps to see if there are actually things to do and how far away everything is, because if it's 20 kilometers from the city, I'm not going to have a car to get there.

[Interviewer] Okay. And anything else you'd want to check for your decision?

[Interviewee] No. I guess what's missing is checking where to stay—seeing if there are hostels. And if there aren't, then go straight to Airbnb.

[Interviewer] Let's see, "hostel Pistoia." Looks like there's something. Where would you go for that, in these cases?

[Interviewee] I'd go to that one—what's it called again... Hostelworld. And I'd start seeing what comes up, if there's anything in that city.

[Interviewer] You were leaving on the 12th and returning the 14th. Let's check... Pistoia... we had said from the 12th to the 14th. But for example, let's see... Okay, Ascoli—nothing. For Pistoia, also nothing.

[Interviewee] Okay. So then I'd go check... well, in the blogs we read, they didn't give accommodation recommendations. So straight to Airbnb.

[Interviewer] Okay. Airbnb. I'm going to get bombarded with ads after this, huh? Pistoia. 12 to 14. Two adults. Okay, and... Ascoli Piceno. Okay, so here you have Pistoia more or less. I don't know.

[Interviewee] Okay. I'd search by area—somewhere central, or where I'll be arriving (train or bus). And near the tourist spots I marked on the map. Let's assume it's where most of the listings are—that should be the center. And for a weekend, I'd try to find something not too large, something close to €100. No more than that, because I'm not moving in.

[Interviewer] Let's say I set a filter—no more than €100. Or let's set €150 as a cap. There are 4 options. And in Ascoli, the same... looks like there are a few more options there. €98. Actually, Ascoli... at €150 there's really only one that's decent. If that's this one. And this one has 4 options. Also near the center.

[Interviewee] Okay, and I'd look for one with several stars, like the two on the left side—rated 4.9. If it looks good or has the services I need, like towels, a bed, that's enough. As long as it has good reviews, I'd go for that. And the final decision would come down to doing the math. Maybe one of the cities costs a bit more with Omio but I can go by train, and it's worth it for the accommodation. The other might be cheaper to get to by plane, but more expensive for lodging.

[Interviewer] And based on what you saw, which one would you be more inclined to visit?

[Interviewee] Which city are these accommodations in?

[Interviewer] These are for Pistoia—that's the destination you'd reach more cheaply by train. And this is Ascoli, which you'd reach more cheaply by plane.

[Interviewee] Okay, but the plane was cheaper than the train?

[Interviewer] Yes, although... I don't want to overload you with info, but you'd land in Abruzzo. I don't remember exactly where that is, but it's not directly in the city—you'd need an extra transfer.

[Interviewee] Oh, then the other one is more convenient.

[Interviewer] Pistoia. Okay. Okay. And just one last thing. You say Pistoia... just for a final detail, let me show you both on the map. And tell me what you think about each one. For example, we have... Pistoia is here. And Ascoli is here. Ascoli; Pistoia.

[Interviewee] Okay. Honestly, not going to one over the other wouldn't really change anything for me. It's like a bonus trip if I get to visit a new place. If I have to choose between the two, I'll go with the one that's more accessible and cheaper—unless it's a city where something incredible happened and I find that out while researching. Otherwise, it doesn't change my decision much. They're smaller cities, you know, it's not like Rome or that I'm missing out on Venice.

[Interviewer] Yes. Perfect. And well... oh, one more thing. Tell me if this is something you'd go see. You mentioned that you like history and cities. This is a sport—but more than that, it's an event for the city. It has a parade and this sport. This one. Is it something you'd go see, or what do you think when you see it?

[Interviewee] Yeah, I'd go see it. I'd stay just a little while, though. I wouldn't spend a whole day missing out on seeing the city just for that. I'd try to be there a bit, see what it's about. If it's really great, maybe I stay longer. But I wouldn't skip all the stuff I had planned to see.

[Interviewer] Okay. Perfect. Well, those were all my questions. I don't know if there's anything else you want to add, something important that you didn't mention.

[Interviewee] No, I think that's everything. I think we covered all the points.

[Interviewer] Perfect. Alright, I'm stopping the recording here.